



## Introduction

Long absent from anatomy texts, paintings, sculptures—and even from consciousness itself—the clitoris has historically been an organ of pleasure systematically erased. This forgetting, however, appears to be undergoing a reversal; it is now the subject of celebration. Conferences are convened in its honor, books and manifestos dedicated to it, artworks inspired by it. Clitoral jouissance is increasingly acknowledged as autonomous.

The contours of feminist discourse have also undergone a transformation. Queer, intersex, and trans perspectives... today, the clitoris may no longer be exclusively defined as a marker of womanhood.

Yet, despite this recognition, it remains a site of trauma. Sexual mutilation persists as a widespread practice, and pleasure continues to be denied to millions of women. The clitoris thus endures as an enigmatic locus of the feminine.

Caught between the extreme difficulty and pressing urgency of recalling the sensations of this place, it is time to allow this organ of pleasure—one that has never fully become an organ of thought—to finally speak.

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Catherine Malabou

# **Le plaisir effacé**

**Clitoris et pensée**

Bibliothèque Rivages



PAYOT & RIVAGES EDITIONS [payot-rivages.fr](http://payot-rivages.fr)

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© Éditions Payot & Rivages, Paris, 2020 for this edition

Published under the direction of Lidia Breda

ISBN: 978-2-7436-5146-6

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A remembrance of Anne Dufourmantelle, resonant with her reflections on tenderness.

“Clitoris, a mysterious ruby in motion, gleaming like a jewel upon the torso of a god.”

Pierre Louÿs

## Effacements

The clitoris is a minuscule stone lodged in secret within the vast landscape of sexual imagination. Young Clitoris, from Greek mythology, known for her delicate size, was said to be slender “as a pebble.” For centuries it remained hidden, nameless, absent from artistic representation and medical treatises, often overlooked even by women themselves; the clitoris existed only as a scruple, in the primitive sense of the word—a grain that irritates the step and gnaws at the mind. The hesitant etymology of the term situates its morphology between “hillock” (kleitoris) and “key” or “fastening” (kleidos). Clitoris: this small, swollen secret that persists, resists, harasses consciousness and wounds the heel—it is the sole organ dedicated to pleasure, therefore “to nothing.” To absolutely nothing, the immense nothingness, the all-or-nothing of female jouissance.

The first anatomical use of the word is attributed to Rufus of Ephesus, a Greek physician from the 1st–2nd centuries CE, who plays hide-and-seek with its synonyms: “The nymph or myrtle is the small piece of muscular flesh that hangs in the middle [of the vulva], others call it hypodermis, others clitoris, and to caress this part is termed ‘to clitorize.’” In French, the name appears in 1575 under the pen of Ambroise Paré, who writes *cleitoris*... then mysteriously removes it from his *Oeuvres* in 1585. Gabriele Falloppio (father of the famous fallopian tubes) could thus claim to have discovered it in 1561. Barely born, already erased.

Twenty-first century. A gynecologist explains before a stunned male audience how the clitoris behaves during lovemaking—in contact with penises, dildos, fingers, tongues—how it moves, what posture it adopts during penetration or caress. An accomplice to the vagina, a teammate. But also a solitary enjoyer. Animated by a dual erotic orientation. It sways when accompanying the movements of the penetrated vagina. It hardens when erect like a crest. Sometimes both together. Sometimes one without the other. Without dwelling on either, the clitoris confounds dichotomies.

This double life, already questioning the norms of heterosexuality, remained unnoticed for centuries. Early attempts at recognizing the clitoris only served to obscure it further by assimilating it to the penis. Freud’s well-known theory of the “failed girl” posits that female genitalia lack a definitive form—a scar of castration, the clitoris is presented as the infirm phallus of women. Even in his work, Freud remains, in his own way, captive to a unisex model. In a bold thesis outlined in *The Fabric of Sex: An Essay on Body and Gender in the West*

, Thomas W. Laqueur demonstrated that from antiquity until the eighteenth century, a vision of sexual unity prevailed, according to which anatomical differences between men and women were considered insignificant. It was believed there existed only one sex: female genitalia resided within the body, while male organs were external. The later anatomical discovery of the clitoris did not entirely dispel this schema.

From this also arose the fantastical construction of the lesbian as an inverted man—a notion radically dismantled by Simone de Beauvoir.

A crippled penis, the clitoris has always been simultaneously associated with excessive pleasure. Incapable of reproduction, effaced yet lubricious. Legend holds that certain gorgons, endowed with prominent clitorises, were condemned to perpetual masturbation. The ablation of the clitoris—clitordirectomy—emerged as a therapeutic means of castrating women a second time, by calming their passions: a radical solution to the problem of pleasure.

Excision is present in all cultures, and not solely in Africa as is often believed. In the West, it was practiced as therapy for hysteria and nymphomania. There are numerous ways to sever the clitoris—physically, of course, but also an extensive range of psychic excisions. Legendary frigidity, the counterpoint to nymphomania, is one such instance.

Absence, ablation, mutilation, denial. Can the clitoris exist in minds, bodies, and unconsciousness other than as a negation?

Things have evolved, it will be said—and this is true. The existence of the clitoris—anatomical, symbolic, political—is now asserted with genuine diversity of perspectives, cultures, practices, militant gestures, and performances. “We must ignite a clitoral revolution!” declares Nadejda Tolokonnikova, of the group Pussy Riot—literally, “cat riots.”

Recent books have fortunately conjured its invisibility.

A whole new geography, aesthetic, and ethic of pleasure is asserting itself, extending far beyond the heterosexual matrix and taking shape in four words: “beyond penetration.” Within feminism itself, the ground has continued to shift. From second-wave to third-wave, and now into the intensely contemporary realm of transfeminism, the discourse has undergone a profound transformation. The designation of the clitoris as the exclusive marker of womanhood is no longer sufficient—or even primary. Queer, intersex, and trans perspectives...the clitoris has become synonymous with a libidinal apparatus that does not necessarily reside within women, disrupting conventional understandings of sexuality, pleasure, and gender. New surgeries, new modes of imagining. From this point forward, Paul B. Preciado proclaims, anyone can connect “a clitoris to the solar plexus”<sup>9</sup>.

—without recourse to an exclusive or universal model.

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And yet,

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I write because perhaps, fundamentally, nothing has truly changed. Partly because sexual mutilation remains tragically commonplace. Because millions of women are still denied pleasure. Because the clitoris persists as, physically and psychically, the organ of effaced delight. But also because to conjure an erasure may invariably lead to erasing it in another form. Is recognizing a reality not simultaneously misrecognizing it? Does illumination not always entail a degree of violence? Caresses with one hand, erasures with the other.

The history of the clitoris can certainly be interpreted as a linear progression—a movement from erasure toward visibility, from strikethrough to existence. Today, in certain countries and circles at least, the clitoris would appear to have finally attained its due dignity. However, between each phase, each sentence within this narrative of “progress” yawns like an abyss. Asserting the clitoris’s existence, detailing its anatomy, emphasizing its importance, or engaging it in performative affirmation are not enough to end the eclipse. All my readings, all my research have led me to conclude that touching the clitoris—figuratively and perhaps also literally—always involves encountering a gap. The clitoris exists only *in* this gap, which neither compromises its autonomy nor diminishes its orgasmic intensity, but paradoxically renders it difficult to perceive as a whole, completed entity.

The gap between the clitoris and the vagina – a subject of so much analysis and psychoanalysis. The gap between the clitoris and the penis. The gap between the clitoris and the phallus, the former refusing, unlike the latter, to abide by its law. The gap between the biological and the symbolic, flesh and meaning. And finally, the gap between the “subjects” of feminism—and, consequently, between feminisms themselves. A gap between bodies. A gap between the anatomical destiny of sex and the social plasticity of gender. A gap between birth assignment and surgical intervention. A gap between the assertion of “woman’s” existence and its rejection as a category. A gap between a unified “we women” and a multiplicity of experiences that preclude both unifying this “we” and universalizing these “women.”

One might therefore be surprised by the choice of an organ—a part of the body, or sex—the clitoris—to give due consideration to this multiplicity of gaps. Why privilege it specifically, rather than other zones, not necessarily genital ones?

Because it is a mute symbol.

Few philosophers have dared to address it directly, while references to other aspects of the female body—breasts, vagina, nymphae, for instance—abound in their work. The phallogocentrism inherent in philosophical language is no longer a matter of conjecture. Jacques Derrida was the first to subject this bias to deconstruction by questioning its fundamental tenets: the primacy accorded to rectitude, to erection (the architectural model underpinning all notions of uprightness), to visibility, and to the symbolism of the phallus—and, consequently, the reduction of woman to a mere vessel, to mother, to vagina-uterus. The pleasure of women remains conspicuously absent from philosophical discourse.

In his *History of Sexuality*, Michel Foucault dedicates not a single line to the clitoris, aside from a brief mention of an “monstrous” hermaphrodite<sup>10</sup>. Beyond that fleeting reference, he neglects its role in the “use of pleasures”<sup>11</sup> altogether—perhaps because it proves too resistant to the “repressive hypothesis”<sup>12</sup>...

Phallogocentrism has organized Western philosophical discourse from its inception and continues to govern it.

Yet, philosophy has always undertaken a scientific and ethical task: to illuminate those aspects of reality that have remained hidden, buried, often repressed. To speak of the clitoris as a philosopher is therefore to bring it into being, to call it forth. But how can this be achieved without once again obscuring it? How can it even be conceived when philosophical language itself constitutes a logical excision?

Secondly, women philosophers who have attempted to resolve this contradiction and introduce the clitoris into thought have faced criticism—even ridicule—from third- and fourth-wave feminists. In *The Second Sex*—a work rightly considered foundational to philosophy—Beauvoir demonstrated courage in confronting the clitoris directly, openly discussing the “two organs” of the woman and the unique nature of a pleasure not necessarily tied to reproduction. However, her approach has been dismissed as essentialist, overly concerned with exploring a supposed female identity.

Since then, other theories have emerged—post-sexual difference, critiques of gender fixity, naturalness, and binary—opening and continuing to open fissures between philosophy and politics, dominant languages and minority languages, Eurocentrism and decolonial perspectives. Consequently, the clitoris has been stripped of its simplistic status as a “genital organ,” a privilege exclusive to women. What indeed is the clitoris for a non-binary subject, an *iel* who identifies neither as male nor female? Isn’t it time to move beyond “the fetishization of the organ and anatomy, the focus on physiology?” Delphine Garday rightly asks. She continues: “This is what [...] Judith Butler suggests, questioning the conceptions of body and erotics at play in the production of the body ‘in parts’”<sup>14</sup>.

However, can we be certain that these new developments regarding sexuality, genders, and bodies—necessary as they may be—have not themselves engaged in a form of erasure?

Why should one refuse to portray the clitoris precisely now that it has just appeared, newly born so to speak? Why should the writings of Simone de Beauvoir, or Luce Irigaray, or even radical Italian feminists like Carla Lonzi or Silvia Federici, be considered necessarily outdated? The clitoris: why not listen again to those who first dared to give it voice?

The stance I articulate here is that of a radical feminist decidedly removed from the position of TERFs (trans-exclusionary radical feminists)—those who contend that acknowledging trans struggles obscures and silences the distinct challenges faced in the pursuit of women’s rights.<sup>15</sup> I maintain an equal distance from those who regard the sexual binary as immutable, who decry what they perceive as excesses within gender theory, dismiss same-sex parenthood, and continue to yield ground to patriarchal structures. Yet, conversely, I resist the wholesale rejection of feminists whose work predates *gender studies*, the very founders of radical feminism.

The clitoris continues to bear even now the mark of a wound against which words crash like waves, barely receding after their impact. This is not to suggest it represents a site of lack, a signifier—the letter or object designated ‘a,’ ‘b,’ ‘c,’ or ‘z.’ Rather, its nature is simultaneously simpler and more complex. Even if its identity need not be

specifically *a woman's* clitoris, it remains an enigmatic locus of the feminine—a place that has yet to find its proper grounding.

I trace this space here through a series of delicate explorations, composed with a simultaneity of revelation and concealment, presented without hierarchical order or judgment. These can be read chronologically—respecting the historical development of feminism—or in a non-linear fashion, forming a cyclical pattern.

My aim is not to prove a point but to amplify several voices and maintain my equilibrium, sustained by them, amidst the profound difficulty and pressing urgency of speaking about the feminine today.

These explorations are themselves miniature clitorises of writing, sketching—without depicting—the status of an organ of pleasure that, remaining tentative, has never fully become an organ of thought.

## Almost Goddesses

### Nymphs 1

“Two species of small lips, termed nymphs due to their attributed function of directing the urinary jet—those which [...] border the upper portion of the vulva within the labia majora.”

Georges CUVIER, *Lessons in Comparative Anatomy*<sup>1</sup>

The term ‘nymph’ possesses a dual origin. On one hand, it denotes mythological deities; on the other, the small lips of the vulva, often misidentified as the clitoris. What does this confusion obscure?

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Who, then, are these nymphs? “Homeric mythology depicts them as goddesses (θεαί) of a rank subordinate to those of Olympus, yet not unwelcome in their deliberations on matters of import. Daughters of Jupiter, they inhabit the earth, dwelling in forests, upon mountain peaks, near river sources, in meadows and caves. We find them in the *Iliad* and the *Odyssey*, accompanying Diana in dances, overseeing human fate, planting trees, presiding over hunts; thus sacrifices were offered to them, either specifically or jointly with Mercury<sup>2</sup>.” The most prevalent image of a nymph is that of a graceful young woman—a vital force of nature, akin to a goddess.

While nymphs are frequently portrayed as untamed creatures, pursued by satyrs, they are sometimes represented conversely as the feminine counterpart to those same figures—the Maenads—renowned for their countless erotic encounters. From this arose the later coinage of the term “nymphomania.”

Due to an anatomical inaccuracy, one mistakenly applied the name ‘nymph’ to what was in fact the clitoris, and thus a ‘nymphomaniac’ came to designate a creature possessed of an exceptionally sensitive organ.

Occupying the space between these mythological nymphs—wise or wanton—and their anatomical counterparts resides Nabokov’s invention, the nymphet, for his *Lolita*. “It sometimes occurs that young virgins, between the ages of nine and fourteen, reveal to certain enchanted travelers—those twice or five times their age—their true nature [...] These are chosen beings which I propose to designate under the generic name ‘nymphettes’<sup>3</sup>.”

An immature creature on one side, the nymphet—a contemporary figure mirroring the mythological nymph—recalls the state of an insect in metamorphosis, intermediate between larva and adult, also termed a nymph or nymphal stage. A young girl with a disturbing charm, provocative in her allure, she awakens desire through her synonymy with what remains concealed, threatening, enticing—between her lips, whose name is withheld.

A common thread unites all these nymphs, nymphlets, and *nymphomanes*. It is said of them that they never achieve satisfaction. Pleasure remains captive within its chrysalis.

The nymph, precisely because she does not experience jouissance, embodies the erotic fantasy par excellence—the ideal woman, possessing no clitoris.

Allow me to first digress briefly to analyze this effacement.

## Images Without Sex: Boccaccio, Warburg, Agamben

### Nymphs 2

In his concise essay “Nymphs,” Giorgio Agamben unveils the essential nature of the nymph: she is *image*.

The book embarks on a compelling retrospective journey, beginning with Bill Viola and tracing a path back to Boccaccio, pausing along the way with Aby Warburg. From what point, Agamben wonders during this exploration, does the familiar divide between the image of woman—*muse*, *nymph*—and actual women originate? This caesura, central to medieval poetry, has never ceased to shape the Western imagination and continues to resonate in contemporary art.

In Boccaccio’s work, the nymph “is the quintessential figure of the beloved” precisely because she embodies pure image. The object of desire whom the lover carries within—concealed in a jewel or purse, depicted in a portrait, enshrined in verse or *blazon*—becomes desirable through her very lack of corporeality. This allows the lover to internalize her, to hold her captive in thought. The nymph is woman transformed into idea; for Boccaccio, the Florentine nymph represents the apex of this idealization.

The nymph thus embodies a fundamental ambiguity: a simultaneous union and disunion of the fantasy of woman and woman herself. Like an insect undergoing metamorphosis, she exists suspended between larval form and full life. “If one were to designate as ‘nymphale’ that poetic realm where images [...] ought to coincide with real women, then the Florentine nymph is already perpetually divided along its two opposing poles—too vividly alive and yet utterly inanimate—leaving the poet unable to bestow upon her a unified existence.” The nymph-image is therefore, in its ambivalence, a “sublime fracture between the sensible world and thought,” the very birthplace of literature. She functions as the aura of the real, its fantastic dimension, forever incomplete. Image and living body remain irreconcilably separate. This image, crucially, possesses no sex.

Paracelsus, meanwhile, “inscribes the nymph within a doctrine of elemental spirits (or spiritual creatures), each intrinsically linked to one of the four elements: the nymph (or undine) to water, the sylphs to air, the pygmies (or gnomes) to earth, and the salamanders to fire.” These beings are in all respects akin to human creatures; they bear a physical resemblance but differ fundamentally in that they “possess no soul.”

Like larvae, they remain unanimated. “It is only through encounter with humanity that these images truly come alive.” Consequently, nymphs must consume the love relationship itself in order to awaken and emerge from their status as image.

But this consumption remains perpetually unattainable. How does one make love to an image? Boccaccio writes that the nymphs “are women,” they “resemble them at first glance.”

They resemble them, yet something is missing... Boccaccio turns to a new image. “It is true that they are all women, but nymphs, for their part, do not urinate.” Agamben argues that in expressing himself thus, Boccaccio demonstrates a “brutal realism.” Is realism truly the point? If it holds that nymphs are reanimated only through sexual union with a man, does copulation then imbue them with life by prompting urination? Is this the essence of realism—a conflation of micturition and orgasm? Indeed, “nymphs do not urinate” signifies their lack of orgasmic experience. They know no sexuality until approached by a male presence. And within the masculine imagination, this act is freighted with a fantastical anatomy.

It comes as little surprise, then, to discover that Boccaccio develops a “vigorous critique of women,” favoring nymphs—stripped of bodily fluids and therefore less threatening.

But what of centuries later? What of Agamben himself, for instance? Are the clitoris and vulva returned to their rightful place? Does the real woman reclaim her agency?

The philosopher alludes only once to the anatomical dimension of nymphs, in a fleeting parenthesis that briefly mentions nymphomania. Returning to Paracelsus, Agamben writes: “Paracelsus here connects with another, older tradition, which inextricably linked nymphs to the realm of Venus and passionate love (a tradition that is at the origin both of the psychiatric term ‘nymphomania’ and, perhaps, of the anatomical use designating as nymphae the labia minora of the vagina<sup>10</sup>).”

The *nymphae* also denoted the clitoris. Agamben remains silent on this point.

Thus, the nymph becomes conflated with the absence of the clitoris—never named, never restored to its reality, to the precise morphology of female sexuality. “Mount Venus,” so cherished by Paracelsus, conceals an enigma of obscuration.

Aby Warburg would later expand upon this very enigma. The nymph is the term the great German art historian assigns to one of his “formulas of pathos” (*Pathosformeln*). These “formulas of pathos” constitute the gestural language of passions—the passions “of Western humanity<sup>11</sup>.” He collects their archetypes in his *Mnemosyne Atlas*, a work he pursued relentlessly from 1921 to 1929. In the *Atlas*, the “Nymph” is *Pathosformel* number 46, corresponding to a plate that “comprises twenty-six photographs, ranging from a Lombard relief of the seventh century to Ghirlandaio’s fresco at Santa Maria Novella [...]12.” Agamben asks: “Where does the nymph reside? In which of her twenty-six epiphanies does she reveal herself? To seek among them an archetype or origin from which the others derive would be to read the atlas against its very grain<sup>13</sup>.”

The nymph is both ubiquitous and elusive, moving through a boundless variety of manifestations that constitute, in essence, her imaginary—or imaginal—existence. Yet this very abundance conceals the locus of the wound that lies dormant between her legs. Warburg refrains from any discussion of her sexuality; the nymphs of the nymph remain

unnamed. There is no recourse to nymphomania, no exploration of desire itself, nothing concerning the lips or the clitoris they contain, and consequently, nothing on pleasure. The image presented is even more abstract than those found in Boccaccio. Now, the life of the nymphs is solely a "historical" one. "We are accustomed to attributing life only to the biological body," Warburg observes, "whereas Nymphale embodies a purely historical existence."<sup>14</sup> Agamben's book concludes on this very point—an absence of resolution.

When anatomists designated the clitoris as a "nymph," did they possess a precise understanding of what they named? Was the vulva not, for them as it remains for many today—philosophers among them—simply an indistinct source encompassing pleasure, reproduction, and urination in equal measure? Perhaps life is not exclusive to biological bodies. To assert this, however, requires resisting the impulse to deny those bodies their vitality.

## Nadja as Not-Being, a Brief Remark on “Woman as Love Object”

### Nymphs 3

I certainly would not have read Agamben's text in the same way had Beauvoir, through her incisive analysis of “woman as love object” in *The Second Sex*, not aroused my suspicions regarding this nymph of writers and poets. “Woman as love object” is at the center of the chapter “Myths,” in which Beauvoir intimately links mythology to mystery and mystery to mystification. The mythology of the nymph, the mystery of the woman's image, are expressions of masculine fantasy—the fantasy of sculpture. The nymph is this malleable material that man shapes as he pleases. “One of the daydreams man indulges in,” Beauvoir writes, “is that of imbuing things with his will, modeling their form, penetrating their substance: woman is par excellence ‘soft clay’ which passively submits to kneading and shaping [...]1.” The “image” of the woman, the nymph, is the result of such molding. The Muse is nothing other than this. “Muses are women2,” Beauvoir writes, but they are women improved because they neither urinate nor experience pleasure—that is to say, in reality, they have no autonomy. “The Muse creates nothing on her own3.”

There follow readings of poets enamored with their nymphs. I was particularly sensitive to the case of André Breton. Entirely captivated by Nadja's beauty, I had never noticed how faithful Breton remained, in this book, to the nymph tradition<sup>4</sup>. Nadja is for him close to the mythological nymph, “a free spirit,” he writes, “something like one of those spirits of the air<sup>5</sup>.” However, as Beauvoir rightly points out, “she opens the doors of the surreal world but she is incapable of giving it<sup>6</sup>.” At best, she is “an oracle that one interrogates<sup>7</sup>.” A “woman deprived of her human foundation,” a woman-child, she becomes a poet... only through the grace of the poet.

We follow all the turns and dives of the undine who gradually takes shape in the waves of writing as her Pygmalion molds her and enjoys her. Yet pleasure is denied to her. No mention is made of it; poetry stops at the threshold of her emotion. The nymph, the Muse “is everything except herself<sup>8</sup>.” If “her only vocation is love,” no one asks whether she returns the affection, whether she attaches herself bodily to this erotic game. Whether she enjoys being loved in words and images.

It happens, therefore, that nymph poetry—even surrealist poetry—gags the chrysalis it claims to cherish so much.

Between January 1928 and August 1932, the Surrealists engaged in a game of sexual truth. Breton provoked his friends in this manner: “To what extent does Aragon consider erection necessary for the completion of the sexual act?” or again: “Does Marcel Noll know where the clitoris is located?”<sup>9</sup>

Breton certainly knew himself where it was located, but he did not subject her to this game of truth nor give her a voice.

The nymphs of philosophers and poets are bound in the night of a shared silence.

## Political Anatomy

Returning to the concrete reality, all female mammals possess a clitoris. In quadrupedal species, it is situated near the vagina and thus stimulated through penetration. Copulation initiates both orgasm and ovulation concurrently. As one biologist observes, “the distribution of ovulatory mechanisms among extant mammals suggests [...] that copulation-induced ovulation represents the ancestral model.”<sup>1</sup> During evolutionary development, “owing to the vertical straightening of the pelvis, the clitoris became an anterior organ—visible, accessible from the front.”<sup>2</sup> Consequently, in women, the clitoris is not (or no longer) located at the vaginal entrance. It has migrated away from it. Spontaneous ovulation, triggered autonomously and cyclically without requiring sexual intercourse, represents a later innovation in evolution. Unlike male orgasm, female orgasm lacks a direct reproductive function. “Having played a predominant role in ovulation,” it has largely relinquished this function in women, existing now primarily as pleasure.<sup>3</sup>

A separation between clitoris and vagina—but is this merely an anatomical detail? If so, wouldn’t we possess greater understanding of orgasm generally, including animal orgasm, about which our knowledge remains scant? The specific question of the female orgasm reveals this particularly acutely: biology and politics become inextricably linked. Indeed, underlying the debates concerning the gap between clitoris and vagina, orgasm and reproduction, lies the fundamental issue raised by the autonomy of women’s pleasure. Does a being therefore exist capable of experiencing pleasure independent of reproduction? Is there, then, pleasure for its own sake? By what right is this privilege granted to the sole mammal able to assert it? Simply acknowledging this exception is insufficient; it must be accepted. The autonomy of women’s pleasure has been—and perhaps always will be—defended, argued for, and constructed.

Evidence of this lies in the ongoing contention surrounding whether female sexual pleasure exists independently of reproduction. In an article with a telling title, “The Truth About the Clitoris: Why It Isn’t Just for Pleasure,” British journalist Zoe Williams writes: “We finally have the results. A study published in *Clinical Anatomy* demonstrates that the clitoris does indeed play an important role in reproduction by activating a series of brain effects [...]—triggering blood flow, increasing oxygen levels and temperature in the vagina, boosting lubrication, altering cervical position—which paradoxically slows sperm while enhancing its mobility.”<sup>4</sup> Evolutionary adaptive logic therefore continues to assert its claims in this domain. All means are still employed to reduce female pleasure to a presumed “functionality.”

The theoretical prominence afforded to the clitoris compared to other parts of the vulva, and the vulva itself—its metonymic fetishization (the part standing for the whole)—stems from its symbolic representation of this independence. It becomes the central element enabling us to construct female sexuality, to consider women as sexual subjects in their own right, who “cease to be married to the penis or the law.”<sup>5</sup> Reducing pleasure to reproductive aims constitutes a denial of it.

The affirmative recognition of the clitoris’s autonomy, however, could itself be a source of anxiety and conflict. Some women wondered what recourse they had when vaginal pleasure remained elusive—when the clitoris achieved an independence that condemned them to remain “cold” during penetration? The psychoanalyst Marie Bonaparte, determined to overcome her own frigidity, did not hesitate to seek a surgical solution. Judging her clitoris too distant from her vagina, she requested Professor Halban, a Viennese physician, to relocate it in 1927. When satisfaction still proved unattainable, she underwent two further interventions, in 1930 and 1931, all to no avail. Marie nevertheless continued to assert that the distance between these organs was generally excessive in women—a claim she sought to substantiate in her article “Considerations on the Anatomical Causes of Frigidity in Women,” published under the pseudonym A. E. Narjani. The study focused on “two hundred women randomly selected from the Parisian population,” their “small triangular region” measured with calipers to determine its proximity to the vagina.<sup>6</sup> “The problem of female frigidity remains shrouded in great obscurity,” she wrote, “and yet, at all times and from all sides has risen the lament of women whom love, even through its most exquisite caress, fails to satisfy.”<sup>7</sup>

Through her experiments, Marie Bonaparte also hoped to convince Freud, “the great excisor,” of the futility of abandoning the clitoral phase. Freud believed that normal female sexual development entailed progressing beyond the clitoral stage of pleasure toward the vaginal stage, in accordance with sexuality’s reproductive function. Marie attempted to demonstrate, at her own expense, that without the clitoris there is no jouissance; the vagina alone remains silent. Why not then attempt to artificially imbue an insensitive vagina with some of the clitoris’s vitality, rather than await an improbable maturation? Freud barely listened. The surgical interventions thus served only to exacerbate the effacement of pleasure.

Closing the gap proved impossible.

## Simone de Beauvoir's "Sexual Existence"

With *The Second Sex*, the vulva enters philosophical discourse for the first time. Sexuality had only recently achieved the status of a legitimate category of thought, largely due to Sartre's influence. *Being and Nothingness*, published in 1943, illuminated the relationship between sexuality and existence—a connection previously unexplored. "Existential philosophies," Sartre writes, "have not deemed it necessary to address sexuality. Heidegger, notably, makes no reference to it whatsoever in his existential analytics, presenting 'Dasein' as asexual. And perhaps sexual differentiation can indeed be considered a contingency for 'human reality'; perhaps the problem of masculine and feminine distinction is irrelevant to that of Existence (Existenz), since both man and woman simply 'exist,' no more and no less." He concedes, however, "these reasons are not entirely convincing."<sup>1</sup>

Sartre then devotes considerable space to desire, briefly mentioning "the erection of the penis and clitoris" and asserting that sexuality, far from being a mere "contingent accident," is instead "a necessary structure of being-for-another."<sup>2</sup>

While Beauvoir acknowledges the significant progress represented by these analyses, she identifies a fundamental problem within them: the risk of ultimately leading to disembodiment. This concern is underscored by the fact that sexuality, for Sartre, amounts to little more than a new iteration of the Hegelian dialectic commonly known as that of master and slave—a suspicion further reinforced by her reading of Merleau-Ponty. In *Phenomenology of Perception*, he too frames sexuality within the context of struggle. Regarding nudity in the sexual act, he writes that "modesty and immodesty [...] take place in a dialectic of self and other which is that of master and slave."<sup>3</sup>

How are we to understand this? Despite affirming the importance of sexuality, existentialist philosophers perceive it as an expression of a fundamental dilemma: the conflict between freedom and desire. "Man cannot be sometimes free and sometimes a slave," Sartre affirms; "he is entirely and always free or he is not."<sup>4</sup> The difficulty lies in the fact that desire reintroduces necessity into the absolute freedom of existence. As Hegel demonstrated, desire is inherently alienating—always tending toward the appropriation of the other, its transformation into an object, its consumption, its annihilation. "It is not enough [...]" Sartre writes, "that anxiety give rise to the incarnation of the Other: it is a desire to appropriate this incarnated consciousness. It naturally extends not through caresses but through acts of grasping and penetration."<sup>5</sup>

Beauvoir quickly recognizes that while the Other theoretically concerns both sexes, women are more often enslaved than enslaving in this dynamic of desire—a slave who, moreover, evokes disgust and terror. "The obscenity of the female sex is that of any gaping thing," she observes; "it is a call to be, as Sartre affirms, like all holes; in itself, woman calls for foreign flesh which must transform her into fullness of being through penetration and dilution. And conversely, woman experiences her condition as a summons precisely because she is 'holed'."<sup>6</sup>

In direct contrast to such pronouncements, Beauvoir achieves a pivotal shift by redirecting the phenomenological-existential investigation of sexuality—as undertaken by Sartre and Merleau-Ponty—toward a "philosophy of sexual existence," a philosophy of lived experience that profoundly reconsiders the question of the desiring body. She does not discard phenomenology but rather transforms it, moving beyond a rigorous description of beings and things as they are to an understanding of them as they appear. The nature of sexuality remains elusive unless one recognizes its inherent phenomenality—its status as a manifestation. Sexuation—what we would now term gender formation—is not instantaneous; instead, it unfolds throughout life in a series of successive presentations of the body both to itself and to others. There is no pre-existing sexed body, only the ongoing incorporation of sex.

However, this process cannot be identical for both sexes, though it does not necessarily imply conflict. Beauvoir certainly does not deconstruct the gender binary but repurposes it as a tool for resistance—resistance against the notion of an Other still overwhelmingly defined by masculine norms. "It has already been observed that man thinks only by thinking the Other; he comprehends the world through the lens of duality [...]" But being naturally different from man, who defines himself as the Same, woman is relegated to the category of the Other; the Other encompasses the woman [...]" she writes.<sup>7</sup> The central aim of *The Second Sex* therefore lies in liberating women from the burden of alterity that obscures their individuality.

The book traces the genesis of women's sexual embodiment and connects their morphology to their development as subjects. The celebrated assertion, "one is not born a woman, one becomes one," serves as a response to Sartre's analysis of female anatomy as matter devoid of history: he posited that it represents openness, lack, incompleteness. Beauvoir counters this by arguing that the woman's body possesses its own inherent fullness, revealing itself over time in accordance with the changing contours of its form. Her sex is a figure that emerges through a series of evolving sketches, in which the mirror plays an integral role—sketches of the child, the young girl, the mature woman, and the elderly woman. Youth, maturity, and old age are not merely biological facts but distinct modes of being. One "has" one's age, yet one "is" young or less young, a state of being that aligns with how the body interacts with the world and how the world responds in turn. To "be perforated," conversely, exists outside any framework of experience; it simply does not exist. And desire is not inherently destructive or alienating but rather an echo, a mirroring of the body's constitution. Beauvoir accomplished what was essential: she subtly transitioned from sexuality to eroticism, and within this shift, acknowledged the long-neglected focal point—the clitoris.

This existential eroticism inevitably entails a critique of Freud. "Freud," Beauvoir observes, "did not devote much attention to the fate of women; it is evident that he modeled his descriptions on those of masculine destiny, limiting himself to modifying a few details." He even maintains that "the libido is consistently and invariably male in essence,



whether manifested in men or women.” This implies that he “refuses to acknowledge the originality of the feminine libido.” According to Freud, woman is—as she would later be for Sartre—a mutilated man. The clitoris remains, for both thinkers, merely a small penis: diminished, severed, castrated.

Beauvoir, of course, refutes these assertions. In her own way, she contests the qualifiers “vaginal” or “clitoral.” The categories “clitoral” or “vaginal,” like the categories “bourgeois” or “proletarian,” she writes, are equally powerless to confine a concrete woman<sup>10</sup>. Nevertheless, *The Second Sex* still stumbles over the bifrontal nature of female pleasure: “One of the great problems of feminine eroticism is that clitoral pleasure remains isolated: it is only around puberty, in connection with vaginal eroticism, that a number of erogenous zones develop in the woman’s body<sup>11</sup>.” If clitoral pleasure does not have to disappear, if it is an unavoidable, irreducible manifestation of embodiment, it truly flourishes only in its relationship to vaginal pleasure, to which it must ultimately concede supremacy.

*The Second Sex* owes much to Helene Deutsch’s *Psychology of Women* (1947), a Polish psychoanalyst who emigrated to the United States and was an orthodox Freudian<sup>12</sup>. Beauvoir, who refers to her work repeatedly<sup>13</sup>, shares with Deutsch the idea that the complexity of female sexuality lies in the relationship between its two organs. However, for Beauvoir as for Deutsch – and as for Freud – this relationship can only be one of progression. Deutsch reprises the idea of the feminine castration complex due to “the absence of an organ<sup>14</sup>.” Consequently, in the little girl, “inhibited activity accepts turning towards passivity,” and the clitoris, which is the active organ, must accept the paradoxical domination of the passive organ, the vagina. Hence the definition of the “feminine woman”: “A true non-frigid woman is one who has succeeded in establishing the maternal function of the vagina and abandoning the claims of the clitoris<sup>15</sup>.”

Defloration, Beauvoir notes, certainly does not always bring the expected pleasure. “We come here to the crucial problem of female eroticism<sup>16</sup>”: the beginning of erotic life is necessarily clitoral, awaiting its vaginal future, a pleasure supposedly revealed with penetration. However, “we have seen that defloration is not a happy fulfillment of juvenile eroticism; it is, on the contrary, an unusual phenomenon; vaginal pleasure does not trigger immediately; according to Stekel’s statistics – confirmed by numerous psychoanalysts and sexologists – barely 4% of women experience pleasure from the first intercourse; 50% do not achieve vaginal pleasure before weeks, months, or even years. Psychological factors play an essential role here<sup>17</sup>.” And “the attitude of the man is of extreme importance<sup>18</sup>.” If he is violent or too brutal in his desire, vaginal orgasm will not occur. And “resentment is the most common source of female frigidity<sup>19</sup>.” Despite everything, it is understandable that if all goes well, if the man proves patient and understanding, the transfer of power between the two organs will proceed as smoothly as possible...

It would be unfair, however, to equate Beauvoir’s analyses with those of Deutsch. Beauvoir thinks about the relationship between the clitoris and vagina as a political one, an expression of inequality between a subject who possesses two organs and a subject who has only one. In patriarchal societies, having only one is a privilege. This is why women are led to abandon one of their own. The critique of this situation is unambiguous. But in the author of *The Second Sex* there is a disconnect between the political advancement of her arguments and her vision of female anatomy. Clitoris and vagina continue to play their traditional roles even as critical reflection transgresses them.

How can we overcome the division between clitoral activity and vaginal passivity, pleasure and reproduction? How is the relationship between commanding and obeying distributed between thought and sexuality?

Has Beauvoir not, in her very exploration of femininity, reintroduced the master-slave dynamic she nonetheless sought to exclude from sexuality?

Philosophy and psychoanalysis represent both a resource and an impediment; no feminism has been able to avoid engaging with them, whether in agreement or opposition. *The Second Sex* bears witness, with exceptional acuity, to the barrenness of this endeavor.

## Dolto, Lacan, and the “Report”

“It is of utmost importance that the girl mourn her clitoral masturbatory fantasies. [...] The solution lies in investment of the vagina.”

Françoise DOLTO, *Psychoanalysis and Pediatrics*<sup>1</sup>

What now of female psychoanalysts? Can we today gauge the difficulty it represented for them—for example, to attempt a public discussion of female sexuality in the last century, just before the advent of sexual liberation? I try, as if within a dream, to imagine Françoise Dolto in 1960, already advanced in years, trembling with apprehension when Lacan entrusted her with the task of presenting a report on the subject at the Amsterdam Congress. She would undertake it, under the title *Female Sexuality: Genital Libido and its Feminine Destiny*<sup>2</sup>—a title and subtitle which, she recounts, were imposed upon her.

The text of the report is lengthy, its voice subdued. Dolto isn't fully present within it; she juggles, circulates, undulates, treads carefully through a minefield. “I was assigned the task,” she said. “France wasn't yet prepared to hear a report delivered by a woman.”<sup>3</sup>

The Congress had been the object of extensive preparation; Lagache and Lacan had devoted two years to it. The text of these preparations, “Directive Propositions for a Congress on Female Sexuality,” is published in the *Écrits*<sup>4</sup>. Dolto's report largely follows its main lines.

At the heart of the debate since the 1920s, the question of female sexuality had led, within psychoanalysis, only to a series of impasses. Has it ever truly emerged from them? Regardless, Dolto had to forge a path and find her voice through several already firmly established theoretical positions—and this within a French Psychoanalytic Society torn by internal struggles.

There were at least four such positions. And all, I mean all, crystallized, fossilized around two central concepts, friends and adversaries: the clitoris and the vagina. Since Freud, the mysterious relationship between these two organs had been, as he termed it, the “black continent” of psychoanalysis—a continent often explored since, yet whose mystery remains undiminished.

First position: Freud—sexual monism, the fundamentally masculine essence of libido, a disregard for the little girl's existence and her vagina, the clitoris understood as a lesser homologue of the penis, construction of the phallic theory of sexuality. Around Freud, a second position comprised his disciples gathered in Vienna, who shared his theses while adapting them to their own perspectives. This includes Helene Deutsch, Jeanne Lampl de Groot, Ruth Mack Brunswick, Marie Bonaparte and Anna Freud. A third position aggregates dissenting disciples—Karen Horney, Melanie Klein and Josine Müller—established in London around Ernst Jones. Based on clinical observations, they opposed Freud on the question of “penis envy.” The nature of this envy, according to them, is secondary and defensive; the “feeling of the vagina” is contemporary with clitoral desire, existing very early in the little girl and not reducible to passive waiting for the male.

Finally, of course, a fourth position: the enormous body of Lacanian thought. The statements from Seminar XIX... or worse, viewed retrospectively, illuminate the framework within which Dolto had to attempt to situate her discourse: contempt for feminism in general and for Beauvoir in particular—a contempt that Lacan never concealed and from which he evidently derived a certain pride.

He recounts, during a seminar, a missed opportunity for discussion with Simone de Beauvoir: “A renowned author [...] contacted me before the publication of *The Second Sex*, inexplicably—for I hadn't yet begun lecturing—believing she required my counsel to illuminate the potential psychoanalytic influences on her work.” Lacan clarifies that he never offered these “advice.” He continues, “When I explained that a thorough consideration of the matter would take at least [...] five or six months, she pointed out, quite reasonably, that a book already in progress could not await such a delay. The conventions of literary production, as they appeared to her, allowed for no more than three or four consultations.” He then declined this “honor.”

The pressure of time alone did not motivate his refusal; Lacan fundamentally disagreed with Beauvoir's central thesis.

What is the significance of this? For Lacan, sexuality is not an exchange, a relationship between two individuals, but a function wholly governed by the laws of language. He revisits in his seminar his provocative assertion: “There is no sexual relationship.” The term “relationship” here may be more crucial than “sexual.” To declare “there is no sexual relationship” implies, among other things, that man and woman are not predestined for one another, nor are they, like animals, instinctively oriented toward each other. Being male or female, in other words, does not reside within the realm of nature. Boys and girls differ from lion cubs, who, regardless of sex, “resemble each other quite closely in their behavior.” “Not you,” Lacan addresses his audience, “because it is precisely as signifier that you become sexualized.” The distinction between animals and humans lies in the latter's necessity to articulate sexuality—to write about it, contemplate it, construct narratives around it, fantasize upon it. Loving discourse constitutes a fundamental modality of erotic experience. “The sexual relationship must be reconstructed through language.” However, this very necessity for discourse paradoxically erases the relational aspect of the sexual act, for two seemingly contradictory reasons. First, because this need is identical for both man and woman, effectively nullifying sexual difference within discourse. Second, because despite being subject to the same linguistic imperative, man and woman fail to truly understand one another in their attempts at communication; there exists no genuine “relationship” between them.

Beauvoir's argument, therefore, collapses. "There is no second sex once language enters the equation. Or, alternatively, regarding what we term heterosexuality, *hétéros*, a word signifying 'other' in Greek, occupies a position of self-emptying within the sexual relationship. It is this void—this offering to speech—that I designate as the place of the Other; the locus where the effects of that speech are inscribed."

Through these complex formulations, Lacan contends that each sex constructs its own discourse by addressing it not to the other with whom one shares intimacy, but to a wholly Other—a figure unknown, an ultimate object of desire—to whom one speaks without expectation of response, and who will never correspond to the physically present partner.

Lacan, then, returns the second sex to the encompassing category of the Other from which Beauvoir had so diligently sought to liberate it. This is not to suggest that the categories of man and woman are devoid of meaning, but rather that they denote incommunicable modes of relating to a shared language—a common desire for the same absolute signifier. That signifier is the "phallus." The phallus is certainly not reducible to the penis, given that sexuality, as we have seen, infinitely transcends genitality. Yet, for both sexes, the phallus—as master, ultimate signifier of desire—can only be conceived as an erection, a vertical icon. "The erect image of the phallus is fundamental; it is singular. There is no alternative but a virile image or castration."

The symbolism of the phallus presents a paradox: though virile in its representation, it does not find embodiment in any particular sex. Female sexuality's autonomy—the specificity of the relationship between clitoris and vagina—derives from this very symbolism and is therefore not a primary concern.

As early as "Directives for a Congress on Female Sexuality," Lacan underscored the simultaneously intractable and ultimately futile nature of the question raised by the existence of two organs—and, consequently, two orgasms—in women. "The rather commonplace opposition between clitoral jouissance and vaginal satisfaction," he writes [note this distinction between "jouissance" and "satisfaction"], "has seen theory reinforce its premise to the point of embedding within it the anxieties of subjects, even extending to revendication—without, however, achieving a clearer elucidation of their antagonism. This is because the nature of vaginal orgasm remains fundamentally obscure. [...] Representatives of the sex, despite their prominence among psychoanalysts, have not succeeded in lifting this veil. [...] They generally resort to metaphors, whose elevated language signifies nothing more valuable than what everyday people offer us with less deliberate artistry."

The rejection of the concept of a second sex retrospectively stems from these unsettling declarations concerning women's inability to resolve their own predicament except through recourse to inadequate metaphor.

No second sex, no specifically feminine discourse, nothing substantive to say about the clitoris and vagina—such is the restrictive framework within which Dolto finds herself immediately confined.

Indeed, she will herself employ "metaphors," attempting to insert personal reflections into the gaps of these constraints. These metaphors are those—more or less successful it must be acknowledged—of the clitoridian "button" and the vaginal "hole," sometimes conflated by the little girl "with the urethral meatus"<sup>13</sup>. Dolto attempts to retain everything: from Freud, she preserves the notion of a libido fundamentally masculine in nature and the concept of stages (from the pre-Oedipal phase through the Oedipus complex) leading to vaginal pleasure; from Beauvoir, she respects the genealogical tracing of the girl and woman's development from childhood to adolescence, from adolescence to adulthood, from motherhood to menopause and old age; from the Jones group, she maintains the theory of an early awareness of the vagina in young girls; and from Lacan, she upholds the thesis of the phallus's primacy.

The initial stage is the infant's eroticism. The young girl "requires time to locate a potential 'hold' on her vulva"<sup>14</sup>. This is followed by a phase in which that grasp asserts itself: "The girl manipulates her labia and her 'button,' the clitoris; through its stimulation, she discovers its voluptuous erection, an experience that initially leads her to hope it will develop into a centrifugal penis"<sup>15</sup>. The girl "constructs for herself an image of a full, turgid phallic form"<sup>16</sup>. From the outset, the little girl's sensations are both vaginal and clitoridian; she possesses "a button with a hole"<sup>17</sup>.

The subsequent Oedipal phase intervenes after a "narcissistic disillusionment." It marks the transition from an envy of a penis perceived as "centrifugal" to one seen as "centripetal," a valorization of cavities, foreshadowing the desire for procreation.

However, both the penis and the "button with a hole" are ultimately governed by the primacy of the phallus—a point on which Lacan finds a compelling ally. Dolto indeed acknowledges that sexual intercourse paradoxically dissolves masculinity and femininity within the unreality of the phallus, an absolute signifier that no one ever truly possesses or embodies: "Coitus is genuinely a surrealist act in the fullest sense of the term, a 'déréalization' signifying for both man and woman a loss of their shared and complementary connection to the phallus"<sup>18</sup>.

For Dolto, the only means of discerning truth amidst this chorus of incompatible assertions lies in her clinical experience—specifically, in attentively listening to children's accounts. She maintains that one must allow children to speak freely, as their symptoms represent reactions to the sexual dysfunctions of their parents. Children are the echoes of adult libido—echoes that psychoanalysts typically fail to heed. In fact, it is children who possess the common sense to remind sexuality of its corporeal origins, from which so many signifiers have estranged it. Dolto's strength resides in giving voice to these children. Indeed, while her presentation was met with a chilling silence by contemporary psychoanalysts, it was warmly received by physicians, surgeons, obstetricians, and gynecologists—many of whom requested copies of her intervention.

Lacan recognizes this, repeatedly acknowledging its significance in his seminars. He observed that the emphasis on the child's perspective was the only genuinely original aspect of the report.

It is likely for this reason that he remarked to her after the Congress and the reading of her work: "Well, speaking as you do, you have remarkable courage!"

Dolto recounts their ensuing dialogue. “I asked him: ‘So, are you challenging everything I’ve said?’—‘I didn’t say that,’ he replied, ‘I simply said you have courage.’” [...] “What I had presented,” Dolto continues, “was [undoubtedly] very different in its approach to female sexuality from the perspective adopted by those men there, who remained entrenched in a sort of psychiatric and philosophical mindset.”<sup>19</sup>

But in what sense was this “approach to female sexuality” so markedly different? How did it depart from established dogma? Caroline Eliacheff, in her book *Françoise Dolto. Une journée particulière*, proposes several answers—all valid, stemming from attentive listening to children. “Was it because [Dolto] suggested that women presenting as heterosexual were, in fact, homosexual, assigning their husbands the role of mother?” she wonders. “Or was it due to her discussion of women pedophiles, unacknowledged as such, whose actions were rationalized by maternal love? Was it perhaps her assertion that she had encountered women who were not at all frigid but profoundly disturbed in their approach to child-rearing, while conventional wisdom held orgasm to be a cure-all? Or was it because she condemned the overemphasis on the daughter’s supposed disappointment upon discovering her lack of a penis—a temporary setback, according to Dolto, from which daughters readily recover [...]?”<sup>20</sup>

What does an article of underwear reveal, and what does it obscure? All these aspects simultaneously? The question also arises as to whether psychoanalysis retains any genuine relevance when applied to female sexuality?

When asked about her own identity—her allegiances, her hidden motivations—Dolto offers this enigmatic response, both artless and astute: “I have absolutely no idea who I am, and I am profoundly grateful to those who love me because through them, I am able to love myself. But I remain entirely ignorant of my own being, and that is why I cannot answer you; I simply do not know where my own femininity resides. It’s—there is an inherent impossibility in speaking about it.”<sup>21</sup>

## How can we fundamentally alter our understanding of the relationship between the sexes, a dynamic so often framed as one of force? How can we move beyond interpreting it through the outdated schema of mastery and servitude?

With Carla Lonzi, these questions take on a wholly new urgency, resonating with the intensity of wildfire. Born in Florence in 1931, Carla Lonzi stands as a pivotal figure in Italian radical feminism. In 1970, she co-founded Rivolta Femminile (Feminist Revolt), a collective born from a group of women centered around the Women's Bookstore of Milan. Dedicated to her cause, she leaves her partner and forgoes her established career as an art critic. She resolutely turns away from academia, refusing publication—despite its promise of success—of her dissertation on *The Relationships Between the Stage and the Visual Arts Since the End of the 19th Century*, completed under the guidance of art historian Roberto Longhi. With this work and a conventional career path, she explains, "at best I could have been 'classified' culturally, and for me, that meant forfeiting my only chance at authentic identity."

Carla Lonzi is not a philosopher by formal training, yet her most celebrated intervention is profoundly philosophical: "Let's Spit on Hegel" (*Sputiamo su Hegel!*), the title of her seminal book-manifesto

Hegel's dialectic of master and slave is presented as a struggle unto death. Two consciousnesses confront one another in a battle for recognition, demanding reciprocal self-sacrifice. To be acknowledged as consciousnesses—not mere objects—each must demonstrate detachment from life itself, revealing a willingness to both die and kill. Ultimately, Hegel argues, one consciousness succumbs to fear and accepts submission; one becomes the master, the other the slave. For Lonzi, this dialectic, this logic of opposition, fundamentally misconstrues both relations between men and women, and those between the vagina and clitoris—the two being inextricably linked. This is not to suggest that Lonzi denies the violence inherent in these relationships; on the contrary, she explicitly condemns masculine domination and its normalization of female sexuality. However, the dialectic of master and slave errs both in its initial premise and its ultimate outcome. "If Hegel had recognized the social origins of women's oppression as he did those of slavery," Lonzi writes, "he would have been compelled to apply the master-slave dialectic to it as well. In doing so, he would have encountered a significant obstacle: if revolutionary analysis can indeed capture the dynamics of social change, the liberation of women cannot be contained within the same framework. Between woman and man, there is no resolution in which one eliminates the other; indeed, the very notion of a power struggle collapses."

The Hegelian schema presupposes the reality of power as its foundational condition. While roles may reverse, power itself remains constant. The project of feminism, then, lies in challenging the *a priori* existence of power—in activating a lever that suspends and disrupts both submission and domination. This lever is difference.

It is within *Let's Spit on Hegel* that the concept of difference first emerges, presented as an alternative to the logic of opposition.

The dialectic proves futile in the face of genuine difference. Feminism, therefore, is not a discourse of liberated slaves.

The woman's difference is directly linked to her sexuality, and the relationship between the vagina and clitoris is its fundamental expression. It was also Carla Lonzi who coined the term "clitoral woman." In her other decisive manifesto, *La Femme vaginale et la Femme clitoridienne* (The Vaginal Woman and the Clitoral Woman<sup>5</sup>), she asserts that "the clitoris must lose its secondary role<sup>6</sup>." It has no need to be subjected to the power of the vagina since female sex is precisely it. "Female sex is the clitoris, male sex is the penis<sup>7</sup>."

The clitoris thus becomes the emblem of woman's libidinal autonomy – of her difference – and consequently the zone of resistance to the heteronormativity of "masculine sexual culture."

Such a rupture with the traditional vision of the two organs first requires breaking the equivalence frequently established between clitoral pleasure and masturbation. Even when practiced with a partner, clitoral stimulation is often considered a form of autoeroticism, "a pleasure experienced in solitude and separation<sup>8</sup>," which allows its assimilation to an infantile activity. "Through masturbation, masculine sexual culture understands not only autoeroticism, but any form of stimulation of the sex organs that is not coitus. [...] According to this culture, Lonzi continues, clitoral sexuality can only be implemented through masturbation, even if it is practiced with a partner<sup>9</sup>." It is important, conversely, to affirm clitoral caress as a sexual relationship in its own right. "In our opinion, the difference between masturbation and non-masturbation lies in the perception of the presence of the other and in erotic exchange, not in the accomplishment of a model of coitus<sup>10</sup> – a model entirely determined by "the ideological values of heterosexual procreative penetration<sup>11</sup>."

The question of clitoral pleasure is inseparable from that, political one, of subjectivation. The affirmation of the clitoral woman is the starting point for a new type of becoming-subject. Lonzi establishes a determining relationship between the clitoris and thought when she declares that being clitoral means for a woman "to think in the first person<sup>12</sup>." It is indeed impossible to think for oneself without knowing oneself, and to know oneself without knowing where one's pleasure lies. In school, writes Lonzi, "young people learn about the functioning of procreation, not sexual pleasure<sup>13</sup>." If an exception exists, it is that – too little questioned – between knowing how to think and knowing how to enjoy. Between knowing how to form one's head and how to lose it.

Hence the concept of self-consciousness (*autoconscience*). A woman's self-consciousness of her sex and pleasure differs from consciousness *of being* like this or that—vaginal or clitoral. It is not about accepting a birth datum, a form of fate. Self-consciousness awakens awareness of what it is conscious *of*, namely the true source of desire. This allows one to first put an end to the guilt fostered by supposed vaginal frigidity. The “vaginal woman” is in fact merely a projection of the masculine sexual schema, a fabrication of the “patriarchal culture [which] succeeded in keeping the clitoris hidden and unused<sup>14</sup>.” “How does it come about that the vaginal woman hesitates to become aware of such a vast sexual problem?” Lonzi continues<sup>15</sup>. Because patriarchal culture is precisely a culture of clitoridectomy.

The clitoral woman becomes the figure of feminine consciousness: “to fully enjoy clitoral orgasm, a woman must find psychic autonomy<sup>16</sup>.” The assertion of sexual difference signifies less confinement within a binary schema than the deconstruction of the concept of equality. Radical feminists do not seek to be treated as equals with men, but to be considered and to consider themselves first and foremost as what they “authentically” are—different. Recognizing oneself as clitoral was at the time a veritable coming out. With the “clitoral woman,” difference came out of the closet.

The critique of the heteronormative construction of female sexuality (the theory of gender is not yet thematically in question) obviously implies for Lonzi also a rejection of Freudian psychoanalysis and its equation between the clitoris and immaturity, which transforms women into “aspiring vaginal beings<sup>17</sup>.”

The refusal of Freudian psychoanalysis resembles the rejection of Hegelian dialectic. “Feminism, for women, takes the place of psychoanalysis for men. In the latter, man finds the reasons that make him unassailable [...]. In feminism, woman finds collective feminine consciousness which elaborates the themes of her liberation. The category of repression in psychoanalysis is equivalent to master-slave in Marxism [and Hegelianism]: both form a patriarchal utopia where woman is seen as the last human being repressed and enslaved to support the grandiose effort of the masculine world that breaks the chains of repression and slavery<sup>18</sup>.” A major stake of feminist self-consciousness, the clitoris now marks the irreducible gap between submission and responsibility.

How to avoid, however, among women, the reconstitution of phallic power? The reduction of the gap?

In her *Journal*, Lonzi poignantly evokes the difficulties she encountered with Ester, her partner, who felt dominated by her. “With Ester, I can only remain silent. She is angry at herself and cannot bear it. Now, she dares to say what she had never expressed before, something that was still unthinkable: that in our relationship, I am the man and she is the woman. Thus, the dichotomy of the vaginal and the clitoral returns, and even feminism will not be able to put an end to it.”<sup>19</sup>

The expression of this pessimism is all the more sorrowful given that Lonzi did not live long enough to witness her victory—the strength and popularity of what would become known, thanks to her and since then, as “difference feminism.” A feminism which continued to develop at the *Libreria delle Donne* in Milan and the *Diotima Philosophical Community* (*Comunità Filosofica Diotima*) at the University of Verona. Lonzi died in Milan on August 2nd, 1982, from uterine cancer, unaware that “sexual difference” would henceforth become, and for a long time remain, the founding term of a new feminism.

## Luce Irigaray: “Woman is neither closed nor open<sup>1</sup>”

The lips of the vulva – and of the mouth – are like guardians or gates that harbor no power dynamic. Lodged between these lips, the clitoris and vagina never compete. For Luce Irigaray, psychoanalyst and philosopher, “woman does not have a sex. She has at least two, but not identifiable as one. Indeed, she has many more. Her sexuality, always at least double, is furthermore plural<sup>2</sup>.”

Thus, “the pleasure of the woman need not choose between clitoral activity and vaginal passivity [...]. The pleasure of vaginal caress does not have to substitute for that of clitoral caress. They concur with one another, in an irreplaceable way, to the jouissance of the woman<sup>3</sup>.”

The absence of any competition between the two organs is as if symbolized, redoubled by the relationship of the lips to each other which hold themselves against one another without pressure. In the secret of this sex that “retouches itself infinitely<sup>4</sup>,” between these lips (those of the sex and those of the mouth) which speak to one another, there is, once again, “neither master nor slave<sup>5</sup>.” Sexual difference, which imposes itself as one of the major political problems of our time, here implies yet another break with dialectics. “Each epoch [...] has one thing to think about. Only one. Sexual difference is that of our time<sup>6</sup>.” But this thought is not a thought of conflict.

Through decisive readings of Plato, Descartes, Hegel, Nietzsche, or Heidegger, Irigaray does not merely determine the destiny of woman in philosophy as a mimetic destiny, which condemns her, when she wields concepts, to imitate men. The thinking woman is not an animated matter, simple copy of the masculine *logos* that is always a form for her. Woman deflects this mimicry and this materiality through an ironic and subversive mirroring effect. *Speculum* is thus a reply to Lacan’s mirror stage, a mirror in which no woman ever reflects herself. The title *Speculum of the Other Woman* certainly evokes the gynecological instrument that allows one to “look into the darkness<sup>7</sup>,” but also reveals, through a strange reverberation effect, that this obscurity resides in the eye of the beholder.

When touching, lips reveal nothing of the mystery they cover, if by “visible” we mean a salient form that can be grasped by the eyes as much as by the hands. As for “matter,” supposedly the ontological share of the feminine, it is not shapeless but unformalizable. “A common noun indefinable in terms of identity. (The/a woman) does not obey the principle of identity<sup>8</sup>.” Further on: “This touching [gives] woman a form that inf(in)itely transforms without closing in on its appropriation<sup>9</sup>.” The unformalizable promises pleasure an infinity of metamorphoses.

In *Ce sexe qui n’en est pas un* (This Sex Which Is Not One), Irigaray sketches a veritable geography of feminine pleasure. If the lips are, in a sense, the very source of libido, it remains nonetheless that “woman has sexes everywhere. She enjoys everywhere. Without even mentioning the hysterization of her entire body, the geography of her pleasure is far more diverse, multiple in its differences, complex, subtle than one imagines... within an imaginary a little too centered on the same.” “She” is inf(in)itely other in herself<sup>10</sup>.

What censure has not been leveled against this articulation of womanhood, these lips! With what skepticism has this manifold topography of pleasure not initially met? It has been alleged that Irigaray opposed vulvomorphism to phallomorphism without qualification—a charge that condemns her to essentialism. The term is ill-suited, for an essence (*eidos*) in the Greek understanding is a movement, the dynamic process of entering into presence or appearing. An essence is anything but a fixed nature or static instance; its subsequent metaphysical constriction does not alter its original plasticity. Indeed, it appears Irigaray herself did not fully recognize the metamorphic character of essence when she reduces it to the immobility of substance. Thus, Irigaray would be essentialist only in degree, if at all, in my view.

It is certain that her thought never truly escapes the theoretical matrix of sexual difference. There exists the feminine and the masculine. “Female sexuality has always been conceived from masculine parameters,” she observes, and woman’s jouissance remains “denied by a civilization which privileges phallomorphism.” However, it must be understood that sexual difference can be conceptualized beyond binary opposition—as an economy that paradoxically transcends it. To speak of binary opposition, in fact, implies a balance, an equilibrium between two terms or values. The very act of speaking of difference introduces disproportion, heterogeneity, and divergence within the duality itself. Irigaray herself emphasizes plurality over dyad, allowing difference to disrupt another familiar pairing: that of the clitoris and the vagina.

“Body, breasts, pubis, clitoris, lips, vulva, vagina, cervix, uterus... and this nothing that already allows them to enjoy in/from their divergence,” she writes. The multiplicity of zones resists unification, remains dispersed—and it is precisely this spacing that carries pleasure beyond the confines of opening-closure, passivity-activity.

But what reproach has not been directed at this very divergence! Valerie Traub contends that it remains trapped, contained within a framework of strict equivalence between body parts and desire. Irigaray’s psychomorphology of the female body, she argues, is still dependent on a “logic of equivalence.” An equivalence between lips and female desire. Yet, according to Traub, this logic is ultimately “assured by the phallus.” It is indeed the phallus which, for Lacan, possesses the “power of naming” and assigning signifying value to a part of the body—thus enabling it to become an emblem of erotic identity.

Was attempting to think and write female pleasure, at the presumed risk of rigidifying identity, not nevertheless a necessary undertaking? Does it not remain so? Nor is it certain that Irigaray succumbed to the trap of a still-phallic symbolization of the clitoris, conferring upon it a value as the principle of women’s bodies. The clitoris, she writes, “resists founding its firmness.”

In proposing her cartography of female pleasure, Irigaray sought to double, redouble—and thus transgress—the Freudian (and, on another plane, Lacanian) conception of female genitalia. To assert the existence of a sex “that is not

one” was to resist reducing sex to itself; it signified diverting anatomical language from its established moorings and redirecting it toward the construction of a body psychoanalysis had never envisioned. But can we now consider such an overflow, first broached by Beauvoir and subsequently radicalized by Irigaray, obsolete? “The reliance on anatomy to substantiate a theoretical stance,” Irigaray observes, “is particularly crucial for Freud in his account of female sexual development. [...] In the name of this anatomical destiny, women are deemed less naturally endowed libidinally, frequently frigid, non-aggressive, non-sadistic, non-possessive, homosexual according to the prevalence of hermaphroditism within their ovaries—alien to cultural values unless they partake in them through some ‘mixed heredity,’ and so on. In essence, deprived of inherent sexual value.” The salient point, she continues, “is, of course, that we lack any understanding of *why* this is so, or *by whom* it is determined, yet it is invariably attributed to ‘Nature’<sup>17</sup>.”

It thus became necessary to dismantle—to dislodge—the Freudian anatomical imperative by juxtaposing it with an alternative bodily schema. Today, that schema is understood as revisable, malleable, not inherently feminine; however, Irigaray laid the groundwork for this transformative reimagining of the body.

Irigaray has also faced criticism for ostensibly writing solely for a lesbian audience. In *This Sex Which Is Not One*, specifically in the chapter “When Our Lips Speak,” it becomes evident that the lips belong to women—at least two—engaged in an intimate embrace: “Luminous, we are,” Irigaray writes. “Neither one, nor two. I never learned to count. Until you. We would be two, according to their calculations. Two, truly? Doesn’t it provoke laughter? A peculiar two. But certainly not one. Let them cling to the one<sup>18</sup>.”

Is this a legitimate concern? Are there not multiple interpretations possible within this scene? And isn’t it fundamentally true that, as Audre Lorde contends, “the authentic feminist must always grapple with lesbian consciousness, regardless of her sexual partners<sup>19</sup>?”



## With tenderness and respect for the blameless vulva<sup>1</sup>

Senators Maryvonne Blondin and Marta de Cidrac, in their 2018 report on “female genital mutilation,” offer two essential terminological clarifications concerning practices too readily termed (as I have myself been guilty of doing) excision or clitoridectomy.

The first pertains to the very expression “female genital mutilation” (FGM), now the official designation in France. This nomenclature represents the culmination of numerous formulations and reformulations undertaken since the late 1950s, reflecting successive shifts in understanding.

“In 1958, when the UN and in 1959 the WHO first addressed these issues,” the authors note, “mutilations were understood as ritual operations rooted in custom.”<sup>3</sup> At that time, excision was largely assimilated to circumcision. However, beginning in the mid-1970s, these “operations” came increasingly to be regarded as acts of violence against women, leading to the official adoption of the term “mutilation.” While the United Kingdom favors the phrase female genital cutting (FGC), and the WHO consistently employs “female genital mutilations” (FGM), French-speaking countries generally prefer “female genital mutilation.” In 2013, the National Consultative Commission on Human Rights (CNCDH) affirmed that “the notion of female genital mutilation refers to the violation of fundamental rights of girls and women,” emphasizing that “these mutilations must first and foremost be combatted within the framework of human rights” rather than “reduced to [medical] problems” or the “biological aspect of the practice” implied by the term ‘genital mutilation.’”<sup>4</sup>

The second clarification concerns the recognition of the diversity of female genital mutilation, a significant departure from perceptions prevalent in the 1950s. “The typology established by the WHO in 1997 and revised in 2007 identifies three main categories of mutilation, all characterized by being performed on the external sexual organs of women without medical justification:

- Type 1 – Clitoridectomy: total or partial removal of the clitoris and/or clitoral hood;
- Type 2 – Excision: total or partial removal of the clitoris and labia minora, with or without removal of the labia majora;
- Type 3 – Infibulation: narrowing of the vaginal opening through the removal and joining of the labia minora and/or labia majora, with or without removal of the clitoris. The resulting scar must be incised at the time of marriage and/or childbirth; this type of mutilation is now primarily located in East Africa.
- Type 4 – All other harmful interventions on the female genital organs undertaken for non-medical purposes, such as pricking, piercing, incising, scraping, and cauterizing.”<sup>5</sup>

According to the National Consultative Commission on Human Rights, a girl or woman is subjected to excision somewhere in the world every fifteen seconds. Of the 200 million currently recorded cases, 44 million involve individuals under the age of fifteen. A report by the Parliamentary Assembly of the Council of Europe contends that “any parallel between male circumcision and female genital mutilation must be rejected, if only because the clitoris—whose sole function is sexual pleasure—has no equivalent in men.”<sup>6</sup> For Dr. Emmanuelle Piet, president of the Feminist Collective Against Rape, these mutilations “aim to suppress female pleasure: as such, they are indeed acts of sexual violence.”<sup>7</sup>

“Halimata Fofana, author of *Mariama, the Living Wound*, remembers the unspeakable pain caused by the repeated movement of the excisor’s knife, the burning sensation from disinfection with 90° alcohol on the raw wound, the inability to walk and sit for several days after the ‘intervention’<sup>8</sup>.”

Another powerful testimony, notable for its style and poetic creativity, is the work of Alice Walker, an African-American feminist writer. Walker situates her activist work at the *intersection* of two struggles: for the civil rights of Black people and for the abolition of female genital mutilation. *The Secret of Joy* (Possessing the Secret of Joy)<sup>9</sup>, written in 1992, is certainly the first novel devoted to the problem of mutilations. It was followed by *Warrior Marks. Female Genital Mutilation and the Sexual Blinding of Women*<sup>10</sup> – a book and documentary film of the same name, directed by filmmaker Pratibha Parmar. Walker undertakes a journey through Africa to explore excision, and the film ends with an interview with an excisor – herself “mutilated” – preparing to perform an ‘operation’.

The opening images of the film show a group of women singing: “We condemn FGM.” One of them, a midwife (Comfort I. Ottah), turns to the camera and says: “This is not culture, it’s torture (this is not culture, this is torture)<sup>11</sup>.” Walker frames the ethical problem in these terms: “How is it possible to be faced with someone who is suffering and not see them? To ignore them to the point of being the one [note the use of the masculine pronoun, he] inflicting that suffering and continuing calmly to inflict it?” Or again: “Being in great pain comes with a certainty: the other who does not suffer doesn’t believe it.” Mutilations are abysses of pain that reverse into insignias of power – the power of those who doubt the pain.

“For a long time, I didn’t understand that I was dead.” These are the first words of *The Secret of Joy*, spoken by Tashi, born in Africa but living in the United States since her marriage<sup>12</sup>. Fidelity to her ancestral culture—that of the (fictional) Olinka society—led Tashi, already Americanized due to her relationship with Adam, son of a missionary, to voluntarily submit, as an adolescent, to the knife of the *tsunga* (excisor). She believed she could thus affirm her loyalty to her people. However, excision is a genuine trauma, which condemns the young woman, now married to Adam, to

struggle throughout her life against madness and attempt in vain to understand the ancestral reasons for the mutilations. She finally finds, through psychoanalysis, a form of bodily integrity. “At the end of my life, I reintegrate this body abandoned so long ago<sup>13</sup>.” But Tashi receives another psychic blow when she recalls the scene of Dura’s excision, her older sister, who died from hemorrhaging following the ablation. She is haunted by the particularly harrowing memory of M’Lissa, the excisor, throwing Dura’s genitals to a hungry hen: “as if she had been waiting for it, the hen rushed onto M’Lissa’s foot, located it, and with a quick movement of her neck and beak, gobbled it up<sup>14</sup>.” For Tashi, excision amounts to murder. She ultimately returns to Africa to take her revenge and kill the excisor with a knife—blade against blade—before being herself sentenced to death.

Three interwoven strands compose the narrative: a condemnation of female genital mutilation, the coerced participation of women in patriarchal structures, and ultimately, the imperative to shatter the silence. The voices of Audre Lorde resonate throughout—“Your silence will not protect you”<sup>15</sup>—echoing alongside those of Toni Morrison and her “re-souvenir (re-memory)” in *Beloved*<sup>16</sup> (in concert with Tashi’s assertion: “if you lie to yourself about your pain, you will be killed by those who tell the story that you brought it on yourself”<sup>17</sup>); and bell hooks: “So many black women are struggling to accept and love our bodies. For some of us, this means learning to love our color. Others manage to embrace it, celebrate it, incorporate it into the eroticism of their language, their mode of address to other women. But so many black women have endured the trauma of abuse; we arrive at sexuality bearing its wounds”<sup>18</sup>.

For Walker, as for all those who join her in chorus, the mutilation of women in Africa is indistinguishable from the physical violence, sexual assault, and rape inflicted upon Black people in the United States—manifestations of slavery’s enduring legacy. As with slavery, female genital mutilation constitutes a symbolic homicide.

Victims or survivors? The most fitting term remains a matter of debate.

## Mutilation and Repair: The Right Words?

However, increasingly numerous voices are challenging the use of the term “mutilations.” Whether they are called genital or sexual makes no difference to them; the term remains inappropriate. Members of the LGBT community, researchers, and doctors today question the relevance of these standard denominations, officially recognized by the WHO, a major actor in the debate. The label female sexual (or genital) mutilation implies, as we have seen, that any non-medically justified intervention on female genitalia is a case of torture, a violation of the right to bodily integrity, and does not primarily relate to cultural practices. The terms FGM/SFG would thus constitute discrimination in themselves<sup>1</sup>. It should be noted that the WHO only takes into account non-Western forms of these interventions.

Why symptomize, singularize, female mutilation and not other interventions performed without consent on intersex children (operations or hormonal treatments), or on all subjects concerned by variations in sexual development, for example<sup>2</sup>? And why exclude circumcision?

In a highly virulent article, “A Critique of the WHO’s Policy on Female Genital Mutilation,” researchers Brian D. Earp and Sara Johnsdotter expose the reasons why anti-FGM laws may appear ethically and legally questionable<sup>3</sup>. “What we primarily question is the terminology used to describe these practices. The term ‘mutilation,’ employed without regard for the severity of the interventions, the context, or the motives that command them, is subject to caution for several reasons<sup>4</sup>.”

Firstly, the term “mutilation” is imprecise. It encompasses a great diversity of operations which do not have the same consequences on sexuality and health. For example, “ritual piercings or incisions, without ablation of tissues, do not necessarily cause functional damage and occasion no alteration of the morphology of external female genitalia<sup>5</sup>.”

Secondly, the term “mutilation” disqualifies the motivations of those who perform or authorize the operations. “It connotes an intention to cause harm or disfigurement. However, parents who request genital surgery for their child – female, male, or intersex / DSD (Disorder Sex Developments) – will never accept talking about mutilation but, rightly or wrongly, about therapy or improvement<sup>6</sup>.”

Let us recall that, according to current medical standards, a body is considered genetically masculine if it has an XY chromosome combination and as genetically feminine if its chromosome combination is XX.

Children referred to as “intersex” (a term itself subject to much criticism) undergo operations to transform their genitals until the onset of preadolescence. If a newborn intersex individual, following chromosomal analysis, is considered genetically female (XX), for example, surgery intervenes to remove genital tissues that could be mistaken for a penis. Reconstruction of the vulva (along with clitoral reduction) generally begins around three months of age. If the visible organ resembles what medical terminology calls a peno-clitoris, this operation in most cases conversely involves transforming the clitoris into a penis.

But at what level of indeterminacy does intervention on a child’s genitals become unacceptable?

Another objection raised against the use of “mutilation” centers on its inconsistent application, never extended to equally invasive Western procedures—such as ‘cosmetic labiaplasty,’ which is gaining popularity among young adolescents in the USA and elsewhere for aesthetic reasons<sup>7</sup>.

It is also observed that “‘mutilation’ is applied indiscriminately to all non-Western forms of genital ablation performed on women, while no form of male genital ablation not medically necessary is officially considered male genital cutting (MGC), regardless of its severity, whether consensual or not, or the dangers it presents<sup>8</sup>.”

Why not then invert the equation—excision equals circumcision (female)—and consider precisely circumcision as a form of excision (male)<sup>9</sup>? The latter also carries risks of infection, herpes, neurological complications when performed with non-sterile instruments and without anesthesia, to say nothing of its potential negative impact on sexual function. Therefore, why prohibit in France, as we have seen, the equivalence between circumcision and excision—an equivalence accepted at the end of the 1950s? Is this prohibition genuinely warranted?

Finally, the term “mutilation” itself is capable of inflicting harm, potentially unnecessarily stigmatizing women, negatively affecting their self-image and esteem, and thus increasing the risk of trauma. Many find it defamatory. It has been observed that young women labeled as “excised,” or described as “without a clitoris” in Western contexts (these designations themselves originating in the West), develop complexes and believe they are irrevocably barred from experiencing pleasure—though “this is not necessarily the case<sup>10</sup>.”

What, then, erases pleasure: mutilation as an act, or mutilation as a designation?

Does mutilation erase pleasure? Can both possible interpretations of this statement be sustained within the subtle gap that separates them? Is there therefore a distance *within* language itself—a division within a single phrase? How (not) to simultaneously acknowledge the condemnations issued by MSF or FGM, and reject the very terms of those condemnations?

“How does one articulate the fairness or justice of such arguments?” asks Delphine Gardéy. “Must one be myopic or inhumane in the name of respecting difference and combating neocolonialism? Is it forbidden to mobilize when witnessing serious harm inflicted on individuals? Can one be an ‘activist’ without despising or condemning other cultures? And are there alternatives beyond these apparent impasses? To critique ‘female genital mutilation,’ is that to impose dominant Western norms? Conversely, to refrain from doing so, is that to endorse such practices as excision or to legitimize their continuation?”<sup>11</sup>

Does feminism today impose itself—is it imposed—as a form of schizophrenia?

## Technologically Modified Bodies

### Paul B. Preciado and Transfeminism

"You strain to wrench my kidneys free, yet they resist. Your touch finds my verdant gallbladder. I turn inward, lamenting, falling into an abyss; my head is dragged along, my heart rises to meet my teeth—it seems my blood has frozen solid in its veins."

Monique WITTIG, *The Lesbian Body*<sup>1</sup>

There are no bodies left untouched, none that exist naturally as they appear, whose gender identity remains unshaped by transformation. Perhaps the line between metamorphosis and mutilation is less distinct than we believe. These questions lie at the core of Paul B. Preciado's work—a transfeminist philosopher who, from *Contra-Sexual Manifesto to Testo Junkie*, through *An Apartment on Uranus* and *I Am This Monster That Speaks to You*<sup>2</sup>, has described and contemplated the intimate interplay between biology and technology, the mutations of psyche, and the plastic construction of identity. From Beatriz—the self they initially inhabited—they evolved into Paul. "I became queer as the AIDS crisis began claiming our brightest minds. I then gravitated toward the transgender movement when hormones became a matter of political contention. Over the past eight years, I've gradually transitioned, using low-dose testosterone gel to sculpt my gender 'woman-to-man.' But for the last six months, I've accelerated the process with testosterone injections every ten days. I also changed my name to Paul. Hair now grows on my legs; my face has become that of Paul. Political subjectivity is forged from language and biomolecules."<sup>3</sup>

In 2017, Preciado legally registered as a "man," yet subjectively resists categorization as either man or woman, declaring himself instead "non-binary."

This work—this journey, this body in constant reinvention—shatters all dichotomies, including that between "cisgender" and "transgender" subjects (cis and trans). The term "cissexual (zissexuell)"<sup>4</sup>, now more commonly "cisgender" (cisgender), emerged around the turn of the millennium to denote "individuals whose gender at birth, body, and personal identity align." Thus, a "cisgender" man or woman is one whose sex assigned at birth corresponds with their social gender. Broader in scope than the category of transsexual, the qualifier transgender characterizes individuals whose gender identity diverges from the sex they were assigned at birth. In Latin, *cis* signifies "on this side," while *trans* denotes "beyond." *Cis-Alpine* historically referred to "this side of the Alps," and *trans-Alpine*, "beyond"<sup>5</sup>.

In truth, there are not two sides but a multiplicity—inclinations, reliefs, borders without number. A multiplicity of genders, even of clitorises. One does not possess gender; rather, it is gender that possesses the subject, setting it in motion as if it were a machine. This machine constitutes a network of logistical, biomedical, and cultural norms systematically disrupting the established heterosexual order. Which woman has not altered her body through estrogen and progesterone? Is a cis woman's body not already transfigured by the hormones within the pill or menopause treatments—to cite merely these familiar examples? Consequently, the subject of transfeminism is neither women nor men, but rather "users of technologies such as the pill, testosterone, Viagra, Truvada"<sup>6</sup>... Today, "a somato-political revolution is underway: a revolt of all vulnerable bodies against the oppression inherent in these very technologies." Drawing inspiration from Donna Haraway, the subject of transfeminism transcends the binary of man or woman, becoming the mutant hacker. The question shifts from "who am I?" and "what is my gender or sexual identity?" to "how does it work?" How can one intervene in its functioning? And, crucially, how might it function differently?<sup>7</sup>

Once again, there exists no pristine body, no form untouched by pharmacological intervention and prosthetics. In this sense, all bodies—not solely those of women—are inherently fragile because they are fabricated, and therefore, vulnerable to mutilation.

While critiquing the excesses of biopolitics, Preciado nonetheless feels no animosity toward biology itself. For him, the constructed nature of gender never negates materiality, the empirical reality—the sanguine, glandular, epigenetic reality—of sex. This materiality is integral to the very genesis of gender. What constitutes the matter of a body? Judith Butler already posed this question in *Bodies that Matter* (Ces corps qui comptent)<sup>8</sup>. For Preciado, gender is inextricably implicated in the corporeal givenness of sex: blood, viscera, organs. This is why gender is not simply performative; "it is purely constructed and simultaneously entirely organic. [...] Its corporeal plasticity destabilizes the distinction between imitation and imitator, truth and its representation, reference and referent, nature and artifice, sexual organs and sexual practices"<sup>9</sup>.

Sex is precisely the exchanger facilitating circulation between the symbolic dimension and the material reality of the body. On one hand, "sex is a technology"<sup>10</sup>; on the other, it cannot exist without "determined organs," "determined anatomical reactions"<sup>11</sup>. Gender fabricates sex, yet simultaneously, sex influences gender, transmitting chemical signals and impulses. The sensitive tissue of the body, therefore, never truly disappears. Regarding his new voice—"masculine"—Preciado declares: "It is with this voice, fabricated but biological, strange yet entirely my own, that I address you today, dear members of the school!"<sup>12</sup>.

Who, then, are these "members of the school"? *I Am a Monster Who Speaks* is the transcript of a conference given in 2017 to an audience of 3,500 French psychoanalysts convened around the topic of women and psychoanalysis—a gathering at which the transfeminist struggle was, it seems, largely unknown. "My discourse," Preciado recounts, "triggered an earthquake at the Palais des Congrès where I presented. When I inquired if anyone in the room identified as homosexual, trans, or non-binary, a heavy silence descended, punctuated by scattered bursts of laughter. When I

called upon the psychoanalytic institutions to acknowledge the ongoing transformation of sexual and gender epistemology, roughly half the audience responded with mirth, while others jeered or demanded my removal”<sup>13</sup>.

Still other attendees defensively asserted the supposedly immutable nature of sexual difference. “Do not suggest,” Preciado retorted, “that sexual difference is not fundamental to understanding the structure of the psychic apparatus in psychoanalysis. The entire Freudian framework was conceived from within patriarchal masculinity—from the perspective of the heterosexual male body understood as one possessing an erect penis, capable of penetration and ejaculation; it is for this reason that ‘women’ in psychoanalysis—these peculiar creatures with (sometimes) a reproductive uterus and clitoris—remain, and always have remained, problematic. It explains why even in 2019 a dedicated day is still required to discuss ‘women in psychoanalysis’”<sup>14</sup>.

A remarkable circuit, taking fifty years to traverse the globe, of psyche and bodies. From Dolto’s address at the Congress on Female Sexuality to the transgender discourse delivered at the Congress on Women and Psychoanalysis, everything has altered, yet nothing truly has changed.

## “Mea vulva, mea maxima vulva”

### Nymphs 4: nymphomaniac

Lars von Trier's *Nymphomaniac* was not well received<sup>1</sup>. Deemed shocking, unnecessarily provocative, and graphic, it had to be softened, and the version circulating today is therefore not the original. The film is composed of two movements, *Nymphomaniac I* and *Nymphomaniac II*. The main character, a woman named Joe (in homage to Jimi Hendrix's song “Hey Joe”), recounts her story in several “chapters” to a man named Seligman. The entire film is a flashback of their conversations.

After asking her neighbor Jérôme to deflower her, the young Joe, daughter of a botanist with whom she is very close, quickly discovers she is a nymphomaniac. Playing with multiple lovers, often at the same time (I would like to dwell on the scene where the betrayed woman, embodied by Uma Thurman, comes with her two young sons to scream her despair at her husband who left her for Joe, who mocks her), she marries Jérôme, found by chance a few years later. The early days of their marriage are happy, and their sexual compatibility is perfect. But abruptly, Joe ceases to experience pleasure, “I don't feel anything anymore,” she says. “In an instant,” she will tell Seligman, “I lost all sexual sensation; my cunt simply went numb.”

Joe and Jérôme have a child, Marcel, whom Joe distances herself from early on after a cesarean section that disgusts her. In order to try to regain pleasure, she multiplies erotic experiences again, with Jérôme's agreement (hence the scene with the two Black men which caused so much shock). But she only finds ecstasy with an anonymous man, a strange professional, whom women pay to hit them; he refuses any sexual commerce with them outside of blows and gives nicknames to his clients without ever knowing their true identity. Joe is “Fido.” We see her, bent over on the armrest of a sofa, tied up, head down, having the flesh of her buttocks lacerated, the only part of her body exposed, with whips and knotted ropes. Pleasure returns, intense. The story with Jérôme does not survive it. The couple separates, and Marcel is placed in public assistance.

Joe must now earn a living, but the office director forces her to undergo therapy because her sexual obsession (she continues her numerous experiences, this time with colleagues) becomes incompatible with her work. She begins group sessions, organized on the model of Alcoholics Anonymous, each “patient” (bizarrely, there are only women) having to begin any contribution with: “I am addicted to this or that.” Joe will therefore comply with the rule and declare: “I am a sex addict.” She would prefer to say: “I am a nymphomaniac,” but the therapist forbids it. The difference between sex addict and nymphomaniac is not justified, simply imposed. Is it therefore more correct to say sex addict? We should examine closely the imposition of this new concept of sex addiction. What does it add? What does it subtract from nymphomania? Can one truly be addicted to sex as one is to heroin? In any case, like Joe, I find this term ridiculous.

Joe initially agrees to submit to the reign of this new terminology, politically correct, but quickly rebels against the therapist, leaves the group shouting her contempt for the other members and once again confidently asserts herself as a nymphomaniac.

Later, she is contacted by a mafia company who, knowing her SM talents and her supposed moral depravity, employs her to forcibly collect debts from its debtors. Accompanied by two enforcers, her task is to make them confess their deepest fantasies and subject them to both physical and psychological torture. Her “boss” then asks her to investigate an adolescent, P, to test her and see if she would be capable of doing the same work. Joe will have a sexual relationship with this very young girl.

It turns out that Jérôme is one of the debtors of the mafia “company.” P is chosen to make him confess and pay, but she falls in love with him and they have an affair, to Joe's despair.

Joe, who says she has never experienced love, except for her father, understands that she is actually in love both with Jérôme and with P, and cannot help but be jealous. One evening, she stalks the lovers in a subway underpass, attempts to kill Jérôme but the revolver jams. Jérôme beats her mercilessly, makes love to P in front of her then abandons her lying on the floor. P, before leaving the basement, urinates on her body. The nymph, this time, pees.

Joe is then saved by a man named Seligman who, taking the same passage, sees her and takes her in. Joe tells him her story, which Seligman punctuates with comments systematically relating Joe's experiences to key moments in Western culture—music, painting, mathematics...and traditions of fishing or hunting.

Joe confides in him her decision to end her past, which for her means complete sexual abstinence. Seligman listens to her with great kindness. However, unexpectedly and terribly disappointingly, he attempts to penetrate her while she sleeps. This time, the revolver does not jam.

This film is of rare intensity, and I believe those who so violently vilified it simply did not understand it. Shaking, magnificent—and Charlotte Gainsbourg is astonishingly nuanced—the film is raw, it's true. But its power of truth, as always with Lars von Trier, is both unbearable and undeniable.

It was important to recall the details of the story, precisely because its subject matter lends itself in no way to a narrative. The gap between the bare fact, without explanation, of sexuality described as hell and the unfolding life of a woman concentrates all the intensity of the film. That is why Joe's journey is not only narrative but above all morphological. Far from the usual “Sexual Lives of...”, *Nymphomaniac* undertakes to show the formation of a body in acute dissonance with its sexuality, from early childhood to adulthood. Five actresses for five Joes. Ronja Rissman is Joe at 2 years old, Maja Arsovich, Joe at 7 years old, Ananya Berg, Joe at 10 years old, Stacy Martin, between 15 and 30

years old, Charlotte Gainsbourg, between 30 and 40 years old. Five Joes who merge into one another, recall each other in dizzying reverberations.

The morphology of sexual dissonance centers on the perplexing abandonment of pleasure—a pleasure that must now be pursued at a great distance, even to the extremes of sadomasochism and beyond, reaching a paradoxical semblance of sanctity in its very elusiveness. Seligman's character emerges as a knowing glance from the divine toward this relentless quest for the absolute. This desertion of pleasure manifests as a wound: specifically, the wound of the clitoris.

Within the film's four-hour duration, the clitoris is glimpsed only once, depicted on an anatomical chart. It remains ambiguous—is it truly a clitoris, or merely the fissure of the lips? The camera dwells instead on Joe's buttocks, and on her sex viewed from behind while she is bound with her tormentor. A single instance of cunnilingus receives close attention, yet the sole genuine, visible representation of the clitoris is that of a wound. One day, Joe discovers blood emanating from her clitoris in the restroom. "My clitoris began to bleed more and more frequently," she recounts. And when P initiates their first sexual encounter, Joe resists, stating simply: "I have a wound."

What causes this bleeding? How can sexual abuse provoke such an outcome? Is it a consequence of the whip's impact—an unlikely explanation given its positioning? It is instead, and more evidently, a symbolic injury, the blank space of compulsion. As if the clitoris remained agonizingly untouchable, both sanctified and cursed—a victim of a devouring vagina, perpetually unfulfilled. In one striking scene, Joe inserts a dozen dessert spoons into it at Jérôme's behest, the clitoris submerged in the blood of its own enigma.

The film's brilliance lies in its precise linkage between nymphomania and both the absence of pleasure and the experience of wounding. Sexuality is revealed as an encounter with violence—physical, social, moral, psychic—accompanied by solitude, atomization, abandonment, and detachment. Only through violence does any semblance of pleasure arise.

Seligman draws a comparison between Joe and the nymph used in fly fishing: a lure constructed from a bead and a lead wire body, adorned with horsehair or bristles, concealing a hook within its form. Young Joe is this nymph—a captivating siren unaware that a small harpoon lies hidden within her body in place of her clitoris.

In *Nymphomaniac*, the nymph represents not inspiration or an ideal, but rather the distress inherent in a body burdened by the death of pleasure. It has been suggested that Lars von Trier prioritizes sex over gender; however, I find this critique unpersuasive (isn't Joe a deliberately non-binary name?). As with all his work, he pauses at the threshold of difference between woman and femininity—a wounded distinction whose organ is never seen directly, only in negative space or through veils of transparency.

My reservation lies instead with the proposed solution of definitive abstinence as a means to alleviate the torments of pleasure. Perhaps von Trier believes that there is no remedy for erased pleasure beyond an intensification of its own erasure.

## Zones of Ecstasy in the Real

"The feminine is to feminism what violet is to lavender."<sup>1</sup>

In *Changing Difference. The Feminine Question in Philosophy*<sup>2</sup>, I revisited and analyzed my experience as a woman philosopher—my intellectual trajectory, my engagement with texts.

I then sought to describe the transformative effects that immersion in a rigorous spiritual discipline—philosophy being but one instance—could exert on sexuality and gender. That experience, singular though it may be, struck me then, and continues to strike me now, as potentially illuminating. The time had come to relinquish the belief that philosophizing and "degendering" were intrinsically linked. Following Irigaray's lead, I recognized that "speaking is never neutral."<sup>3</sup> I needed to abandon the pretense of philosophical subjecthood's asexuality—the defense most frequently employed by women seeking survival within the concentrated masculine force field of traditional discourse.

Today, I find myself less preoccupied with tracing phallocentrism in texts than with exploring philosophy's somatic power of formation. Contrary to common assumption, it shapes bodies, as I have previously argued regarding the relationship between thought and its counterpart—the brain. Philosophy does not merely act upon bodies with corrective intent; it is not simply a training regimen. It also sculpts an erotics that fosters novel connections between spiritual and libidinal energies. I speak not of idealized or metaphorical sexuality, but rather of discourse's sexualizing effect.

Entering philosophy and entering my body ultimately coalesced into a single experience. It is self-evident that my body has undergone transformation since the advent of thought—if I may put it so. Or rather, I now inhabit several bodies. Thus, perhaps more accurately: "entering philosophy and entering my bodies became one." The effort to fluidify desire, to enrich my "sexual relations" with partners both real and virtual, logical and textual, has also shaped my sex itself, infusing it with a novel vibration, palpitation, an existence divorced from sublimation.

There is no non-binary mind coupled with a clitoridian body of mine. Intellectual non-binarity is the antithesis of desexualization. Similarly, clitoral libido remains inseparable from intellect. My clitoris awakens in synchronicity with my brain; a line of fire extends the length of my being. Curiously, this very sensation challenges me to "identify" sexually, as existing categories grow increasingly porous.

I was once a girl, defined by fairly conventional gender norms that I consistently subverted. Philosophy has been—and remains—the triumph of that subversion. It fueled the doubt regarding my femininity which enabled the proliferation of my genders, and thus a renewed questioning of that very same femininity. My clitoris already possessed a dual existence: sexual and gendered, anatomical and social. Philosophy added the political dimension of a transgender clitoris.

The term "feminine" strikes me as the least ill-suited for describing this condition: a feminine existing outside of sexual difference, beyond the constraints of heteronormativity—a feminine of subjectivation. I do not subscribe to the critiques leveled against the word "feminism," which is often suspected, unlike transfeminism, of prioritizing identity politics over processes of disidentification. Jacques Rancière rightly observes that "all subjectivation is a disidentification, a wrenching from the assumed naturalness of one's place, an opening of a space where anyone can be counted, precisely because it is a space for counting the previously uncounted." In political discourse, "woman" functions as the subject of experience—a subject stripped of its essential nature, defeminized—measuring the distance between a recognized claim to belonging and its absence.

I recognize that this may be difficult to accept or articulate, but I maintain that "woman" and "feminine" are not entirely interchangeable. It is this very excess of the feminine over the woman—a plasticity of gender exceeding gender itself—that the clitoris makes perceptible. Its affinity with the feminine resides in their shared capacity to endure erasures, mutilations, the violence inflicted upon them, as indestructible revenants marking an empty yet open space.

Indeed, I believe that around this concept, various feminisms might, if not find common ground, at least engage in mutual listening. Allow me to illustrate with three examples.

Silvia Federici, the Italian radical feminist and author of the widely-read *Caliban and the Witch*. Women, Bodies, and Primitive Accumulation<sup>6</sup>, recently faced considerable criticism for accusing both gender theory and transfeminism of obscuring the very question of the feminine in her latest work, *Beyond the Borders of the Body*<sup>7</sup>. While I do not defend her position, I believe I understand her frustration and pain. She contends that "if 'women' are evacuated as a political-analytical category, then feminism itself vanishes<sup>8</sup>." This assertion, which tends to universalize an experience of oppression, is certainly open to debate<sup>9</sup>. However, as Mara Mantanaro astutely points out in her insightful review of the work, Federici's argument actually centers more on the feminine than on the woman: "The bodies of women," writes Mantanaro, "are [...] a field of intersection between material and symbolic forces; they are not an anatomical destiny. The central aim of the feminist revolt has always been [...] to denaturalize femininity—that is, to dismantle the notion of what a woman *should* be and do<sup>10</sup>." Precisely, the feminine can once again be defined as that which remains after the denaturalization of the woman. Its haunting presence proves irreducible; any attempt to erase it immediately transforms it into a phantom limb. Like a clitoris excised. This is why its negation elicits such profound suffering. I share Federici's skepticism toward a feminism divorced from the feminine.

The flaw in Federici's argument lies in her assumption that gender theory or transfeminism are unconcerned with this skepticism and summarily dismisses the persistence, the spectral quality, of the feminine.



A second voice emerges. In *I Am a Monster That Speaks*, Preciado writes: "I decided to stop being a woman. Why couldn't the abandonment of femininity become a fundamental strategy of feminism?"<sup>11</sup> This statement initially appears at odds with Federici's, yet Preciado is speaking here of the woman as subject, not the concept of the feminine itself. To dismiss and to mourn are distinct acts. Paul relinquished femininity, but perhaps not the feminine; all his books bear the imprint of that grief. "Contrary to what medicine or psychiatry believes and advocates," he observes, "I did not completely cease to be Beatriz in order to become only Paul. My living body—not my unconscious or consciousness, but my very flesh which encompasses everything in its constant mutation and multiple evolutions—is like a Greek city, where coexist, with differing energy levels, trans-contemporary buildings, a post-modern lesbian architecture, and beautiful Art Deco houses, but also old rural dwellings, beneath the foundations of which remain classical animal or vegetal ruins, mineral and chemical foundations willingly invisible. The traces that past life has left in my memory have become increasingly complex and interconnected, forming a mass of living forces [...]"<sup>12</sup> What remains is perpetually alive. The feminine clearly occupies an entire shelf within this library of the body...

A third striking reflection on this difficult relationship to the feminine comes from Jack Halberstam, a transgender American theorist and academic, who analyzes the resentment some lesbians harbor toward FTM (Female-to-Male) trans people who, in their view, "betray" the feminine by ceasing to be women. "Some lesbians seem to see FTMs as traitors to the 'women's' movement, joining the other side and going over to the enemy. Some FTMs view lesbian feminism as a discourse that demonizes them and their masculinity. Some 'butch' consider that FTMs are butch who 'believe too much in anatomy,' and some FTMs think that butch are FTMs who are afraid to transition."<sup>13</sup>

This remarkable text demonstrates that the "abandonment" of a gender is a highly contentious issue within non-heterosexual circles, even sparking border wars between queer and transgender communities. In an earlier work, Halberstam posed this seemingly naive question: "How is it that, in these times of gender transitivity, when we have agreed that gender is a social construct, does transsexuality become such a wide-scale phenomenon?"<sup>14</sup> Does transsexuality imply a kind of anatomical reaffirmation? A renaturalization of gender through sex? Halberstam further states: "I was also implicitly inclined to prefer non-operated transgender individuals to identified transgender people."<sup>15</sup> This reflection is particularly interesting because it dares to question what, exactly, is abandoned in the case of transition with surgery. What disappears and what remains of the feminine?<sup>16</sup>

One might argue that similar questions arise regarding the "masculine." That masculinity does not necessarily coincide with virility or the anatomical fact of being a man is undeniable. However, so many studies, analyses, and representations—artistic or otherwise—have been devoted to this anatomy, this virility, the logics of masculinity in general, that one cannot conclude there is an equilibrium between them and approaches to female anatomy, its representations, its schemata, reduced to a few clichés. There is, quite obviously, a disproportion of visibility. Hence the necessity of continually evoking the ghost—that is, the reality of the feminine.

How, then, can a philosopher's experience illuminate these questions for those outside the discipline? It is akin to any confession, any recounting of initiation, trauma, or transformation. Within this narrative, "I" am no more uniquely "I" than anyone else; agency is not ours to claim. The biological body exists never in isolation, nor is it self-contained. It invariably extends beyond its initial boundaries (Beauvoir speaks of "transcendence"), molded by discourse, norms, and representations. A body is perpetually a conduit, a nexus of circulation—a form of telepathy—between anatomical reality and symbolic projection. Were the body merely an anatomical fact, it could not survive its injuries. It must remain embedded in the world, and this process of accommodation demands an exit from self, a construction of a platform between the biological and the symbolic, body and the flesh of existence. The symbolic is not matter's tomb; rather, it is its relocation. Philosophy serves as my platform—a single instance among many—of re-identifying through disidentification. Hundreds of others exist.

For me, the only way to confront philosophical phallogentrism is to affirm the non-binary nature of philosophy—though this affirmation does not equate to neutrality. This non-binarity bears witness to its deconstructible character. The dismantling of any systematic conceptual structure necessarily proceeds through what Derrida termed a "defective cornerstone." Indeed, this "cornerstone" reveals the presence of another sex and another gender within texts, elements that alone render them intelligible—a clitoral zone of the *logos*.

The clitoris inscribed in texts marks the locus where philosophers find pleasure and relinquish identification with their anatomical sex and social gender. This space is not always readily apparent; established canons of interpretation predictably attempt to obscure it—though without success. Within the gaps of these texts, a multitude of forms take root, unsettling the framework of Western *logos* and opening it, however slightly, to foreign bodies and uncatalogued modes of jouissance.

But I do not subscribe to philosophical essentialism. The platforms connecting the biological to the symbolic are once again countless. Reality itself readily lends itself to the symbolic projection of bodies; it is speckled with clitoral zones—ecstatic regions that might resemble Freudian erogenous zones, were that concept to have followed a different trajectory.

What, then, do these zones of ecstasy within reality reveal?

This question allows me to express my unease regarding certain assertions about the clitoris that still strike me as overly phallic in their framing. "How does one become and affirm oneself as a subject between the powerful penis and the erect clitoris?" was the title of an issue of *Point[s] d'accroche*. The organizers noted in their introduction that the clitoris is often equated with power, arguing: "Does becoming a subject necessarily imply a 'power' akin to that championed by the logic of virile domination?" they asked. "Is masculinity therefore the sole model for self-affirmation as a social subject? Does pleasure exist only as powerful, dominant, erect [...] Can one not represent the clitoris outside of a power dynamic—the clitoris being described by Tiphaine Dee in *Sur les docks* as even "more powerful" than the

penis because it is the sole organ of the human body exclusively dedicated to pleasure, endowed with the maximum number of nerve endings?"

Preciado does not consistently eschew a discourse of power and success, either. Reading *Un appartement sur Uranus*, I was struck by this metaphor: "We drive along the bay of San Francisco, alongside the Pacific Ocean. Annie Sprinkle is at the wheel, and I am her co-pilot with her dog, Butch. [...] Annie Sprinkle observes that San Francisco is 'America's clitoris,' the smallest and most potent organ in the nation—121 km<sup>2</sup> hyper-electrified, spawning the silica networks that connect it to the world. Where once there was a gold rush, now there is cybernetic fervor. Sex and technology. Sun and dollars. Activism and neoliberalism. Innovation and control. Google, Adobe, Cisco, Ebay, Facebook, Tesla, Twitter... 121 km<sup>2</sup> concentrating one-third of the United States' venture capital."<sup>20</sup>

I find little to distinguish this vision of the clitoris as hyperpower from the classic image of the erect phallus.

This "America's clitoris" calls to mind Roland Barthes' celebrated distinction between the *studium* and the *punctum* in a photograph. "The *studium*, says Barthes, informs me about the subject of the photo, allows me 'to encounter the intentions' of the author, enter into harmony with them—approve or disapprove, but always understand them [...]"<sup>21</sup> The *studium* evokes "a sort of vague, smooth interest."<sup>22</sup> But suddenly, something "breaks (or scans) the *studium*. This time, it is not I who seek [the intentions], [...] it is he who departs from the scene, like an arrow, piercing me. [...] I will therefore call this the *punctum* [...]. The *punctum* of a photo is that chance which, within it, points (but also bruises, grips) me."<sup>23</sup> "America's clitoris," defined as a concentration of power, functions as a *punctum*. If the body of America constitutes a *studium*, California-clitoris would be this arrow that pierces, points, traverses the broad expanse of 'average affect,' interesting but ultimately unremarkable territory.

For me, contemplating the clitoris—or rather, allowing it to think—involves moving beyond the duality of *studium-punctum*, which inevitably leads back to the dichotomy of passivity and activity and its deleterious consequences, both for the logic of virility that it implies and for the return to a vaginal/clitoral binary it instigates.

Clitoral pleasure is not the result of a breakthrough, a penetration, or an incision. This also suggests that if zones of ecstasy in reality are indeed also zones of meaning production, this meaning manifests without prominence—in every sense of the word.

Pleasure resides between the *studium* and the *punctum*, in their écart; it is neither one nor the other. The clitoris – like the feminine – relates to power but not as a relationship of power. In any case, that is how mine thinks.

The clitoris is an anarchist.

## Clitoris, Anarchy, and the Feminine

An-arkhia, in Greek, denotes literally the absence of principle (*arkhè*)—that is to say, of command. Without command implies also a lack of beginning. The *arkhè* establishes a temporal order by prioritizing what comes first, whether in the realm of power or chronology. Anarchy, therefore, signifies without hierarchy or origin; it questions dependence and derivation.

For centuries, “anarchy” has signified little more than disorder and chaos. Aristotle defined it as the condition of an army lacking a strategist—a force that scatters suddenly, losing all sense of its provenance and destination. The soldiers look back only to find emptiness.

In the mid-19th century, anarchists reversed these negative connotations, asserting that “anarchy is order without power.” Soldiers without leaders must learn self-organization; an order devoid of command or beginning is not necessarily chaotic—indeed, it may represent a different arrangement altogether, a composition free from domination. It proceeds from its own internal impetus and expects nothing of others: an order of things unburdened by imposed directives.

The complicity between the clitoris and anarchy arises initially from their shared status as outlaws, from their secret, hidden existence. The clitoris has long been considered a disruptive force—a superfluous organ, deemed useless, mocking the anatomical, political, and social order with its libertarian independence, its dynamic of pleasure detached from all principle and purpose. One cannot govern a clitoris. Despite repeated attempts to impose mastery upon it—patriarchal authority, psychoanalytic dictates, moral imperatives, the weight of custom, the leaden burden of ancestry—it resists. It resists domination by virtue of its very indifference to power and potency.

Potency is meaningless without effectuation, without performance, as demonstrated by the application of a law, an edict, a decree, or even mere advice. Potency invariably awaits actualization. Acts, principles, laws, decrees are in turn dependent on the docility and good will of those who execute them. Act and potency thus weave an inextricable web of subordination. The clitoris exists precisely neither in potency nor in act; it is not a nascent virtuality awaiting vaginal fulfillment, nor does it conform to the model of erection and detumescence. It interrupts the logic of command and obedience—it does not direct. And that is what proves so unsettling.

Emancipation requires identifying the tipping point at which power and domination begin to subvert themselves. The notion of *autosubversion* is central to anarchist thought. Domination cannot be overturned from without alone; it possesses its own internal fracture line, a prelude to its possible ruin. Any instance that demonstrates indifference to the pairing of act and puissance exasperates systems of domination while simultaneously revealing their inherent fissures. The clitoris inserts itself into the very intimacy of power—normative, ideological—in order to expose the breakdown that constantly threatens it.

Clitoris, anarchy, and femininity are, for me, indissolubly linked, forming a conscious front of resistance aware of the authoritarian tendencies even within resistance movements. The defeat of domination remains one of the greatest challenges of our time. Feminism is clearly among its most vibrant expressions—a particularly exposed spearhead precisely because it lacks an *arkhè*.

But the absence of principle does not equate to a lack of memory. It therefore seems crucial to me that we do not sever feminism from femininity. Femininity, above all, serves as a reminder—a stark recollection of the violence inflicted upon women, both in the past and present, encompassing mutilation, rape, harassment, and femicide. The clitoris is, quite plainly and in numerous respects, the very repository of this memory, simultaneously symbolizing and embodying the intolerable nature of female sexual autonomy. Simultaneously, as I have previously noted, femininity extends beyond the confines of womanhood itself, dismantling its naturalization to project, past the baseness of perpetrators both grand and petty, a political sphere defined by an indifference to domination.

Femininity thus binds this memory inextricably to that anticipated future.

## 1 Effacements

1. It wasn't until 2019 in France that "five secondary school textbooks began to represent the complete anatomy of the clitoris" (Marlène Thomas, *Libération*, October 4, 2019).

2. Rufus of Ephesus, *On the Names of Human Body Parts*, Paris, Daremberg-Ruelle, 1879, p. 147.

3. See Michèle Clément, "Anachronism and the Clitoris," *Le Français préclassique*, no. 3, Paris, Champion, 2011, p. 27–45. Also see Christian Boudignon, "You Speak Greek Without Knowing It," *Connaissance hellénique*, no. 28, July 7, 2014.

4. Odile Buisson, "The G-Spot and Female Orgasm," TED Talk, ERNEST series, June 7, 2014. An extraordinary talk in which the existence of the mysterious "G-spot" is called into question.

5. Thomas W. Laqueur, *Making Sex: Body and Gender from the Ancient World to the Enlightenment*, trans. Michel Gauthier, Paris, Gallimard, 1992.

6. See Simone de Beauvoir, *The Second Sex* (1949), vol. II, Paris, Gallimard, "Folio" collection, 1976, chap. IV: "The Lesbian." Also see Valerie Traub who argues: "Since the advent of psychoanalysis, the clitoris and the 'lesbian' have been mutually implicated, as sisters in shame: one being the disturbing sign of the other" ("The Psychomorphology of the Clitoris," *GLQ*, vol. 2, 1995, p. 82).

7. For example Delphine Gardey, *Politics of the Clitoris*, Paris, Textuel, 2019; Camille Froidevaux-Metterie, *The Women's Body: The Battle for Intimacy*, Paris, Philosophie Magazine Éditeur, 2018; Maïté Mazaurette and Damien Mascaret, *The Revenge of the Clitoris*, Paris, La Musardine, 2016; the articles by Michèle Clément, "Anatomism and the Clitoris," *Le Français préclassique*, no. 3, Champion, 2011, p. 27–45, and Sylvie Chaperon, "'The Throne of Pleasures and Voluptuousness': Political Anatomy of the Clitoris from Antiquity to the End of the Nineteenth Century," *Cahiers d'histoire. Revue d'histoire critique*, no. 118, 2012, p. 41–60.

8. Martin Page, *Beyond Penetration*, Paris, Le Nouvel Attila, 2020.

9. Paul B. Preciado, *An Apartment on Uranus*, Paris, Grasset, 2019, p. 258.

As their names suggest, "phallogocentrism" and "phallogocentrism"—terms employed by Jacques Derrida—denote the central importance accorded to phallic symbolism. See, for example, *Glas: Speculations on a Specter* (Paris, Galilée, 1974), p. 85 sq.

11. Stefanos Milkidis, "Foucault: On the Monstrosity of the Hermaphroditic Body," *Queer Cats Journal of LGBTQ Studies*, vol. 2, no. 1, pp. 1–12. Also see Josée Néron, "Foucault, the History of Sexuality and the Condition of Women in Antiquity," *Les Cahiers de droit*, vol. 36, no. 1 (1995), pp. 246–291.

12. Volume II of Michel Foucault's *The History of Sexuality* is dedicated to *The Use of Pleasure* (Paris, Gallimard, 1984).

13. For Foucault, the "repressive hypothesis" reflects the common understanding of power as a force of prohibition and censorship—particularly in matters of sexuality. He demonstrates that, in practice, prohibition paradoxically creates the very sexuality it seeks to repress. See *The History of Sexuality*, vol. I: *The Will to Know* (1976), Paris, Gallimard, coll. "Tel," 1994, p. 14.

14. Delphine Gardey, *Politics of the Clitoris*, op. cit., pp. 145–146. Also see Judith Butler, *Gender Trouble: Feminism and the Subversion of Identity* (1990), Paris, La Découverte, 2005, p. 228 sq.

15. The terms TERF and SWERF are frequently linked. SWERF is an acronym for Sex-Worker-Exclusionary Radical Feminist, a designation applied to feminists who oppose prostitution, viewing it as a form of oppression.

## 2 Almost Goddesses

1. Georges Cuvier, *Lessons in Comparative Anatomy*, vol. 5 (Paris, Crochard, 1805), p. 122.

2. Eduard Adolf Jacobi, *Universal Mythological Dictionary or Mythic Biography*, vol. 1, trans. Thomas Bernard (Paris, Firmin-Didot, 1854), pp. 343–344.

3. Vladimir Nabokov, *Lolita* (1959), trans. E. H. Kahane (Paris, Gallimard, 1973), p. 27.

## 3 Images Without Sex: Boccaccio, Warburg, Agamben

1. Giorgio Agamben, *Nymphs*, trans. Daniel Loayza (Paris, PUF, 2019).

2. *Ibid.*, p. 73.

3. *Ibid.*, p. 78.

4. *Ibid.*, p. 63.

5. *Ibid.*, p. 71 (emphasis mine).

6. Quoted in *ibid.*, p. 77.

7. *Ibid.*, p. 77.

8. Quoted in *ibid.*

9. *Ibid.*

10. *Ibid.*, p. 68.

11. *Ibid.*, p. 84.

12. *Ibid.*, p. 25.

13. *Ibid.*, p. 26

14. *Ibid.*, p. 86.

## 4 Nadja Without Being One: A Brief Remark on “the Woman as Love Object”

1. Simone de Beauvoir, *The Second Sex*, vol. I, op. cit., p. 291.
2. *Ibid.*, p. 299.
3. *Ibid.*
4. André Breton, *Nadja*, Paris, Gallimard/Le Livre de Poche, 1964.
5. *Ibid.*, p. 128. Quoted by Beauvoir, p. 368.
6. *Ibid.*, p. 369.
7. *Ibid.*
8. *Ibid.*, p. 375.
9. Archives du surréalisme, vol. 4: *Researches on Sexuality*, José Pierre (ed.), Paris, Gallimard, 1991, p. 72.

## 5 Political Anatomy

1. Pierre-Henri Gouyon, quoted in Lise Barneoud, “Female Orgasm: We Know Where It Comes From,” *Science et vie*, no. 1228, January 2020, p. 106.
  2. Gérard Zwang, *Praise of the Cunt, Defense and Illustration of the Female Sex*, Paris, La Musardine, 2008, p. 48.
  3. “Female Orgasm: A Mystery of Evolution Finally Solved?” *Science et avenir*, August 3, 2016.
  4. Zoe Williams, “The Truth about the Clitoris: Why It’s not just Built for Pleasure,” *Guardian*, November 6, 2019.
- See also Roy J. Levin, “The Clitoris: An Appraisal of its Reproductive Function During the Fertile Years: Why Was It, and Still Is, Overlooked in Accounts of Female Sexual Arousal,” *Clinical Anatomy*, November 5, 2019, London, Wiley.
5. Paula Bennett, “Critical Clitodirectomy: Female Sexual Imagery and Feminist Psychoanalytical Theory,” *Signs*, no. 18, 1993, p. 257, quoted by Valerie Traub in “The Psychomorphy of the Clitoris,” art. cit., p. 100.
  6. A. E. Narjani (Marie Bonaparte), “Considerations on the Anatomical Causes of Female Frigidity,” *Revue bi-hebdomadaire des sciences médicales et chirurgicales*, vol. 27, no. 4, April 1924.
  7. *Ibid.*

## 6 Simone de Beauvoir’s “Sexual Existence”

1. Jean-Paul Sartre, *Being and Nothingness. An Essay on Phenomenological Ontology*, Paris, Gallimard, 1943, p. 451-452.
2. *Ibid.*, p. 453.
3. Maurice Merleau-Ponty, *Phenomenology of Perception*, Paris, Gallimard, “Tel” collection, 1945, p. 194.
4. Jean-Paul Sartre, *Being and Nothingness*, op. cit., p. 94.
5. *Ibid.*, p. 468.
6. *Ibid.*, p. 706.
7. *Ibid.*, p. 122.
8. *Ibid.*, p. 81.
9. *Ibid.*, p. 82.
10. *Ibid.*, p. 107.
11. *Ibid.*, p. 85.
12. Helene Deutsch, *The Psychology of Women*, 2 vols., trans. Hubert Benoit, Paris, PUF, 1953–1955.
13. See Marie-Andrée Charbonneau, “Female Sexuality in Simone de Beauvoir and Hélène Deutsch,” *Simone de Beauvoir Studies*, vol. 21: *Coast To Coast With Simone de Beauvoir*, Brill, 2004–2005, p. 43–53.
14. Helene Deutsch, *The Psychology of Women*, op. cit., p. 272.
15. Deutsch, as cited in Marie-Andrée Charbonneau, “Female Sexuality in Simone de Beauvoir and Hélène Deutsch,” art. cit., p. 49.
16. Simone de Beauvoir, *The Second Sex*, vol. II, p. 174.
17. *Ibid.*
18. *Ibid.*, p. 175.
19. *Ibid.*, p. 176.

## 7 Dolto, Lacan and the Concept of “Relationship”

1. Françoise Dolto, *Psychoanalysis and Pediatrics*, Paris, Seuil, 1971, p. 107.
2. Françoise Dolto, *Female Sexuality. The Genital Libido and Its Feminine Destiny*, Paris, Gallimard, 1996.
3. “Preliminary Dialogue,” in *ibid.*, p. 34.
4. Jacques Lacan and Daniel Lagache, “Directives for a Congress on Female Sexuality,” *Écrits*, Paris, Seuil, 1966, p. 725.
5. Jacques Lacan, *Seminar XIX... or Worse...*, Paris, Seuil, 2011, p. 69.
6. *Ibid.*
7. *Ibid.*, p. 28.
8. *Ibid.*
9. Jacques Lacan, *Seminar XXIV. The Insufficiency of Knowing the One-Slip of the Tongue Takes Wing*, 1976–1977, unpublished, online, p. 6.
10. Jacques Lacan, *Seminar XIX... or Worse...*, op. cit., p. 69.

11. Jacques Lacan, *Seminar IV. The Object Relation*, Paris, Seuil, 1994, p. 49–50.
12. Jacques Lacan, “Directives for a Congress on Female Sexuality,” op. cit., p. 727–728.
13. Françoise Dolto, *Female Sexuality*, op. cit., p. 91.
14. Ibid., p. 83.
15. Ibid., p. 88.
16. Ibid.
17. Ibid., p. 90.
18. Ibid., p. 172.
19. Remarks reported by Magali Taïeb-Cohen, in “What Women Owe to Dolto,” European Foundation for Psychoanalysis Colloquium, online text, p. 7.
20. Caroline Eliacheff, *Françoise Dolto. A Particular Day*, Paris, Flammarion, 2018, p. 181.
21. “Interview with Jean-Pierre Winter,” as cited in ibid., p. 183–184.

## 8 Carla Lonzi and the Feminism of Difference: “The Female Sex is the Clitoris.”

- 1 Carla Lonzi, opening words of *La Donna clitoride* and *La Donna vaginale e altri scritti*. Scritti di Rivolta Femminile (1974), et al/Edizioni, Milan, 2010. (My translation; a French translation is not yet available, p. 3).
- 2 Cited in Michèle Causse and Maryvonne Lapouge (eds.), *Écrits, voix d’Italie*, Paris, Des Femmes, 1977.
- 3 Carla Lonzi, *Crachons sur Hegel. Une révolte féministe*, trans. “Les derniers masques,” Paris, Eterotopia, coll. “Rhizome,” 2017.

- 4 Ibid., p. 49.
- 5 Carla Lonzi, *La Donna clitoride...*, op. cit.
- 6 Ibid., p. 12.
- 7 Ibid., p. 2.
- 8 Ibid., p. 13.
- 9 Ibid., p. 12.
- 10 Ibid., p. 13.
- 11 Ibid., p. 12.
- 12 Cited in Claire Fontaine (the collective), “We Are All Clitoridian Women: Notes on Carla Lonzi’s Legacy,” *e-flux journal*, no 47, September 2013, online edition, p. 6. The citation originates from Lonzi’s diary, *Taci, anzi parla: Diario di una femminista* (Be Silent, or Rather Speak: Diary of a Feminist), Milan, Scritti di Rivolta Femminile, 1978, p. 9.
- 13 *La Donna vaginale...*, op. cit., p. 14.
- 14 Ibid., p. 21.
- 15 Ibid., p. 7.
- 16 Ibid., p. 4.
- 17 Ibid., p. 6.
- 18 Ibid., p. 8.
- 19 Carla Lonzi, “Tais-toi, ou plutôt parle,” op. cit., p. 267, cited by Elena Dalla Torre in “The Clitoris Diaries: *La Donna clitoride*, Feminine Authenticity, and the Phallic Allegory of Carla Lonzi’s Radical Feminism,” *European Journal of Women’s Studies*, 2014, vol. 21, no 3, p. 227.

## 9 Luce Irigaray: “The Woman is Neither Closed Nor Open.”

- 1 Luce Irigaray, *Speculum de l’autre femme*, Paris, Minuit, 1974, p. 285.
- 2 Luce Irigaray, *Ce sexe qui n’en est pas un*, Paris, Minuit, 1977, p. 27.
- 3 Ibid., p. 28.
- 4 Ibid.
- 5 Luce Irigaray, *Éthique de la différence sexuelle*, Paris, Minuit, 1984, p. 117.
- 6 Ibid., p. 14.
- 7 Luce Irigaray, *Speculum*, op. cit., p. 369.
- 8 Ibid., p. 284.
- 9 Ibid., p. 289.
- 10 Luce Irigaray, *Ce sexe qui n’en est pas un*, op. cit., p. 28.
- 11 Ibid., p. 23.
- 12 Ibid., p. 26.
- 13 Luce Irigaray, *Speculum*, op. cit., p. 289.
- 14 Valerie Traub, “The Psychomorphology of the Clitoris,” cited work, p. 102.
- 15 Ibid.
- 16 Luce Irigaray, *Speculum*, op. cit., p. 287.
- 17 Luce Irigaray, *Ce sexe qui n’en est pas un*, op. cit., p. 70.
- 18 Ibid., p. 207.
- 19 Audre Lorde, “An Interview with Audre Lorde,” *American Poetry Review*, vol. 9, no. 2, 1980, p. 21.

## 20. “With tenderness and respect for the blameless vulva.”

21. "With tenderness and respect for the blameless vulva" ("This book is dedicated, with tenderness and respect, to the blameless vulva"), dedication by Alice Walker, epigraph of her novel *The Secret of Joy* (1992), trans. Louise Tréham, Paris, J'ai Lu, 1994.

22. Maryvonne Blondin and Marta de Cidrac, Information Report made on behalf of the delegation for women's rights and equal opportunities between men and women on female genital mutilation, Senate, no. 479, ordinary session of 2017-2018, registered with the presidency of the Senate on May 16, 2018. Accessible online.

23. Ibid., p. 9.

24. Ibid., p. 9–10. In Africa, a United Nations seminar in 1991 on "Practices Affecting the Health of Women and Children," held in Burkina Faso, definitively recommends the term FGM and the abandonment of "female circumcision."

25. Ibid., p. 12.

26. Ibid., p. 20.

27. Ibid., p. 138.

28. Halimata Fofana, *Mariama l'écorchée vive*, Paris, Karthala, 2015. Cited in the Senate report, p. 5.

29. Alice Walker, *Le Secret de la joie*, op. cit.

30. Alice Walker and Pratibha Parmar, *Warrior Marks: Female Genital Mutilation and the Sexual Blinding of Women*, New York, Harcourt Brace, 1993. Documentary available on Vimeo.

31. Cited by Tobe Levin, "Alice Walker, Activist. Matron of FORWARD," in Maria Diedrich, Henri Louis Gates, and Carl Pedersen, *Black Imagination and the Middle Passage*, W.E.B. Dubois Institute series, 1999, p. 240.

32. Alice Walker, *Le Secret de la joie*, op. cit., p. 9.

33. Ibid., p. 25.

34. Ibid., p. 75.

15. Audre Lorde, "Your Silence will not Protect You," *Sister Outsider*, New York, Crossing Press, 1984, p. 41.

16. Toni Morrison, *Beloved* (1987), trans. Hortense Chabrière and Sylviane Rué, Paris, Christian Bourgois, 1989.

17. Alice Walker, *Le Secret de la joie*, op. cit., p. 102.

18. Bell Hooks, *Sisters of the Yam: Black Women and Self-Recovery*, New York, Routledge, 2015, p. 133.

## **\*\*11 Mutilation and Repair: The Right Words?\***

1. For example: "The hearing of Dr. Ghada Hatem, founder of La Maison des femmes in Saint-Denis, on December 14, 2017, demonstrated the difficulty of isolating female genital mutilation from broader issues of violence against women, revealing excision as part of a continuum that includes forced marriage, rape—particularly marital rape—and domestic abuse." (Maryvonne Blondin and Marta de Cidrac, *Rapport d'information*, op. cit., p. 1).

2. In English, the condition is typically referred to as Disorders of Sex Development (DSD). The French equivalents are *Troubles du développement sexuel* (TDS) or *Troubles de la différence sexuelle*. However, *Variations du développement sexuel* is preferable, avoiding any pejorative implication. We use "disorders" or "variations" to describe instances where an individual's biological sexual characteristics (chromosomal, hormonal, anatomical) diverge from established gender norms.

3. Brian D. Earp and Sara Johnsdotter, "Current critiques of the WHO policy on female genital mutilations," *International Journal of Impotence Research*, December 2020, pp. 1-43, available online at [www.academia.edu/422817](http://www.academia.edu/422817) (my translation).

4. Ibid., p. 4.

5. Ibid., p. 5.

6. Ibid., p. 6.

7. Ibid., p. 7.

8. Ibid., pp. 4-5.

9. "Male genital cutting (MGC) encompasses ritual piercings (hatafat dam brit, for example), as well as other procedures such as urethral abrasion, penile bleedings, incisions on the penis shaft, foreskin splitting (observed among various ethnic groups in Papua New Guinea), and forced circumcision as a punitive measure. It also includes subincision [...] practiced by Aboriginal Australians, and castration (rarer today but still occurring among hijras in India) and amputations." (ibid., p. 6).

10. This is not to mention the term "repair," used to describe reconstructive operations of the genital area. What, precisely, constitutes a "repaired woman"?

11. Delphine Gardey, *Politique du clitoris*, op. cit., p. 90.

## **\*\*12 Technologically Modified Bodies\*\***

1. Monique Wittig, *Le Corps lesbien*, Paris, Minuit, 1973, p. 33.

2. Paul B. Preciado, *Manifeste contra-sexuel*, Paris, Balland, 2000; *Testo Junkie. Sexe, drogue et biopolitique*, Paris, Grasset, 2008; *Un appartement sur Uranus*, op. cit.; *Je suis ce monstre qui vous parle*, Paris, Grasset, 2020.

3. Paul B. Preciado, "Trans-fem.i.nism," *Purple Magazine*, F/W24, 2015, p. 1 (my translation).

4. The term was coined by physician and sociologist Volkmar Sigusch, who employs it in his articles "Die Transsexuellen und unser nosomorpher Blick I," *ZfS*, vol. 4, no. 3, 1991, pp. 225–256, and "The Neosexual Revolution," in *Archives of Social Behavior*, no. 27, 1998, pp. 331–359.

5. More precisely, these adjectives describe Gaul as perceived from Rome; *transalpin* and *cisalpin* can function as synonyms or antonyms depending on the observer's vantage point.

6. Paul B. Preciado, "Trans-fem.i.nism," op. cit., p. 1.

7. Ibid., p. 4. See also Gayle Salamon, *Assuming a Body: Transgender and Rhetorics of Materiality*, New York, Columbia University Press, 2010.

8. Judith Butler, *Ces corps qui comptent. De la matérialité et des limites discursives du « sexe »*, trans. Charlotte Nordmann, Paris, Éditions Amsterdam, 2018.

9. Paul B. Preciado, *Manifeste contra-sexuel*, op. cit., p. 16.

10. Ibid., p. 12.

11. Ibid., p. 14.

12. Ibid., p. 39.

13. Paul B. Preciado, *Je suis un monstre qui vous parle*, op. cit., p. 11.

14. Ibid., p. 80.

## 15 "My vulva, my greatest vulva."

16. Lars von Trier, *Nymphomaniac I et II*, 2013.

## 17. Zones of ecstatic experience within the real.

18. A free rendering of Alice Walker's phrase: "Womanism is to feminism as purple is to lavender," in Alice Walker, *In Search of Our Mothers' Gardens: Womanist Prose*, London, Hachette UK, 1983.

19. Catherine Malabou, *Changer de différence. Le féminin et la question philosophique*, Paris, Galilée, 2007.

20. "The neutrality of the logos is a position often adopted by feminine thought. When it comes to demonstrating what is true and just, the notion that being male or female would be irrelevant—this idea tends to form more readily in the feminine mind, and it is therefore not surprising that we encounter it more frequently expressed by women than by men" (Luisa Muraro "Le penseur neutre était une femme," *Langages*, no. 85, 1987, p. 35).

21. Jacques Rancière, *La Méésentente, Politique et philosophie*, Paris, Galilée, 1995, p. 60.

22. Ibid.

23. Silvia Federici, *Caliban and the Witch. Women, the Body, and Primitive Accumulation*, trans. by the Seronevo collective, reviewed by Julien Guazzini, Geneva, Entremondes, 2017.

24. Silvia Federici, *Par-delà les frontières du corps. Repenser, refaire et revendiquer le corps dans le capitalisme tardif*, trans. Léa Nicolas-Teboul, Paris, Divergences, 2020.

25. Ibid., p. 25.

9. Mara Mantanaro, "Resisting and Powerful Bodies in Silvia Federici: A Strategy of Feminist Insurrection," *Contretemps: Journal of Communist Critique*, June 18, 2020. See also Elsa Dorlin, "Toward an Epistemology of Resistance," in *Sex, Race, Class. For an Epistemology of Domination*, ed. Elsa Dorlin, Paris, PUF, 2009.

10. Ibid., p. 4.

11. Paul B. Preciado, *I Am a Monster That Speaks*, op. cit., p. 27.

12. Ibid., p. 47-48.

13. Judith/Jack Halberstam, "Transgender Butch, Butch/FTM Border Wars and the Masculine Continuum," *GLQ: A Journal of Lesbian and Gay Studies*, vol. 4, no. 2, Duke University Press, 1998, p. 287.

14. Ibid., p. 289.

15. Ibid.

16. Halberstam concludes: "there exists a variety of *gender-outlaw bodies* under the sign of non-normative masculinities and femininities. The task, then, is not to determine who best embodies resistance but to undertake the study of their distinctive traits" (ibid., p. 292).

17. Jacques Derrida, *Memoirs for Paul de Man*, Paris, Galilée, 1998, p. 82 sq.

18. Point[s] d'accroche, online journal; argument posted by Céline Guilleux on April 29, 2015.

19. Another question posed by the organizers was: "Does the stereotype of the 'powerful' woman promoted in political, economic, and cultural spheres genuinely represent liberation? Might it not be the inverse of the dominated woman's image—two sides of the same coin, representing a frightening femininity deliberately held at arm's length?" They further note that "in 2008, the issue of *Cahiers du genre* dedicated to 'The Flowers of the Male. Masculinities Without Men?' featured Marie Hélène/Sam Bourcier and Pascale Molinier asking: 'Could masculinity be the future for women?' By 'masculinity,' they refer to a 'source of empowerment and pleasure,' asserting that 'when positively embraced, it constitutes one possible avenue for transforming class, gender, race, and sex identities.'"

20. Paul B. Preciado, *An Apartment on Uranus*, Paris, Grasset, 2019, p. 264-265.

21. Roland Barthes, *Camera Lucida: Notes on Photography*, Paris, Cahiers du Cinéma/Gallimard/Seuil, 1980, p. 50-51.

22. Ibid.

23. Ibid., p. 48-49.

24. Ibid., p. 48.

## 15. Clitoris, Anarchy, and the Feminine



1. Pierre-Joseph Proudhon, *Les Confessions d'un révolutionnaire*, for the History of the February Revolution, Paris, Hachette livre BNF, 2012.

This electronic edition of Catherine Malabou's *\*The Erased Pleasure\** was produced on October 1, 2020 by Payot & Rivages Publishers.

It is based on the print edition of the same work (

ISBN: 978-2-7436-5145-9

).

The ePub format was prepared by PCA, Rezé.